

LIVING & WORK LITERACY



WORKPLACE & COMMUNICATION ISSUES



Brian Parker



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6

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Brian Parker

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Brian Parker has worked in education for more than 38 years, as a teacher, head teacher of social sciences, school inspector and principal. He retired as Principal of Northmead High School in NSW in 1995. He is currently an author of textbooks in the areas of Geography and Commerce, the most recent titles being *Geography for Global Citizens (3rd edition)*, *Geography for Australian Citizens (3rd edition)* and *Commerce for Australian Citizens (2nd edition)*, for Macmillan Education. Brian has written six books in the series *Living and Work Literacy* for Blake Education, covering topics such as consumerism, government and law, small enterprises and work education.

Brian's teaching experience included a period on exchange in the United Kingdom which has since generated an ongoing interest in photography and overseas travel.

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ABN 50 074 266 023
108 Main Road
Clayton South VIC 3169
Ph: +61 3 9558 4433
www.blake.com.au

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Introduction

The photocopiable activities in this title explore the world of work, with special emphasis on issues in the workplace. Throughout these topics, students will explore general issues such as the nature and pattern of employment in Australia, types of management structures and the role of trade unions in the workplace. They will also focus on skills development, especially developing effective communication skills, and discover practical suggestions for dealing with issues like workplace harassment, bullying and unfair dismissal. The topics also include real-life scenarios and case studies. Concepts are reinforced through a range of challenging short answer, class discussion and research activities.

Topics contained in this book are suitable for secondary school subjects in years 7–10 that teach young people about the practical skills and knowledge that they need to participate fully in society. Other books in this series cover topics such as money and being a wise consumer, government and law, and managing small enterprises.

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1 Employment in Australia

Employment in Australia is measured by the Australian Bureau of Statistics (ABS). The ABS is responsible to the Federal government for providing statistics on a wide variety of topics, such as:

- Australia's population – estimated each month
- census data – detailed counting of the population every five years, e.g. 2001, 2006
- regional statistics – based on postcodes
- labour force and employment statistics
- national accounts – e.g. gross domestic product, national income
- social trends – e.g. housing, travel to work
- the economy
- industry
- the environment and energy.



Key figures for April 2008

	Mar 2008	Apr 2008	Mar 08 to Apr 08	Apr 07 to Apr 08
Trend				
Employed persons ('000)	10 686.5	10 706.1	19.6	2.8 %
Unemployed persons ('000)	455.2	453.1	-2.2	-5.4
Unemployment rate (%)	4.1	4.1	0.0 pts	-0.3 pts
Participation rate (%)	65.3	65.3	0.0 pts	0.4 pts
Seasonally adjusted				
Employed persons ('000)	10 687.6	10 712.9	25.4	2.9 %
Unemployed persons ('000)	452.9	469.8	16.9	-0.9 %
Unemployment rate (%)	4.1	4.2	0.1 pts	-0.2 pts
Participation rate (%)	65.3	65.4	0.2 pts	0.6 pts

Notes: 1 The participation rate refers to the proportion of the working age population who are actually in the workforce.

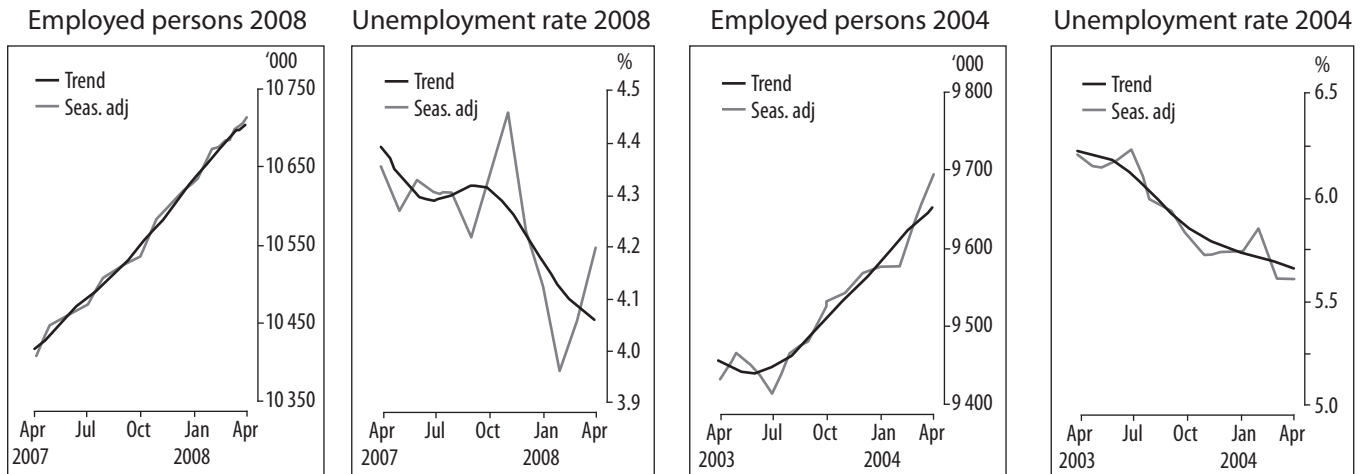
2 'Seasonally adjusted' statistics take account of times like Christmas and Easter when working conditions are different.

Source: Australian Bureau of Statistics 6202.0 Labour Force, Australia, April 2008

Key figures for April 2004

	Mar 2004	Apr 2004	Mar 04 to Apr 04	Apr 03 to Apr 04
Trend				
Employed persons ('000)	9 632.2	9 653.7	21.5	2.1 %
Unemployed persons ('000)	580.3	579.2	-1.1	-7.6
Unemployment rate (%)	5.7	5.7	0.0 pts	-0.6 pts
Participation rate (%)	63.7	63.7	0.1 pts	0.0 pts
Seasonally adjusted				
Employed persons ('000)	9 638.0	9 694.2	56.2	2.8 %
Unemployed persons ('000)	573.1	575.9	2.8	-7.8 %
Unemployment rate (%)	5.6	5.6	0.0 pts	-0.6 pts
Participation rate (%)	63.7	63.9	0.3 pts	0.3 pts

Source: Australian Bureau of Statistics 6202.0 Labour Force, Australia, April 2004



Source: Australian Bureau of Statistics 6202.0
Labour Force, Australia, April 2008

Source: Australian Bureau of Statistics 6202.0
Labour Force, Australia, April 2008

Activities

- 1 What do the letters ABS stand for? What does this organisation do?
- 2 Refer to the statistics and graphs for 2008.
 - a What was the unemployment rate in April 2008 (seasonally adjusted)? Did it increase or decrease from the previous month?
 - b How many people were employed in April 2008?
 - c What is meant by the participation rate? What was it in April 2008, seasonally adjusted? Did it change from the previous month?
 - d What differences were there between the basic figures and the seasonally adjusted ones?
 - e What does 'seasonally adjusted' mean? Why is this done?
 - f How would you describe the trend in the 2008 employed persons graph?
 - g How would you describe the trend in the 2008 unemployment graph?
 - h What possible reasons might there be for the large variations in seasonally adjusted unemployment? Note the months when the 2008 graph is low.
- 3 Refer to the statistics and graphs for 2004.
 - a What was the unemployment rate in April 2004 (seasonally adjusted)?
 - b What happened to the unemployment rate between April 2004 and April 2008?
 - c What happened to the participation rate between April 2004 and April 2008?
 - d Suggest possible reasons for these changes you described in the last two questions.
 - e Describe the changes in the two graphs between 2004 and 2008.
 - f Calculate the difference in the number of employed persons between April 2004 and April 2008. Suggest a reason for this difference.
- 4 Why are these figures published by the Australian Bureau of Statistics? Who might make use of them?



Use the Internet or newspapers to research the latest employment statistics in Australia.

How are they different from the information on these pages?

2 Trade unions today

What are they and how did they begin?

A trade union is a group of workers who unite to promote and defend wage rates and working conditions through common ideals and actions. The principle of unionism is that a group acting collectively can exert more power than an individual can in negotiating for better wages and working conditions.

Trade unions have always generated considerable debate within the community, with many people fiercely opposed to them and many people strongly supportive of them. Australia's history is littered with struggles between employers and trade unions, such as the Great Shearers' Strike of 1891 – one of the first big industrial disputes in Australia. A more recent example is the 1998 Maritime Unions dispute.

The Australian Council of Trade Unions or ACTU was formed in 1927. It is the national organisation authorised to speak on behalf of the unions. At the state level there are Trades and Labour Councils (TLCs) which represent unions in issues affecting individual states. The ACTU and the TLCs have common aims. The most important ones are:

- wages
- hours of work
- working conditions (including health and safety)
- welfare issues.

The ACTU lists on its website five reasons to join a trade union, which are summarised below.

- 1** Protection against unfair treatment at work
- 2** Workplace health and safety
- 3** Better wages and conditions
- 4** Membership benefits (such as cheap loans, discounts on goods)
- 5** Support for better workplace laws (such as unfair dismissal, setting minimum wages)

STRANGE BUT TRUE!

- ✂ Trade unions began in England in 1834 when six farm labourers in the village of Tolpuddle in Dorset formed a group to discuss their working conditions. They were charged with forming an illegal association and sentenced to seven years transportation. They have since become famous as the 'Tolpuddle Martyrs'.

The ACTU states that all Australian workers have the right to join a union: 'Whether you work in a small or large business, in an office or on a construction site – there is a union to represent you.'

Trade union issues today

Trade union activity today is highly dependent on the current state of industrial relations in the country and on the legislation that reflects it. Industrial relations laws are very complex and often the subject of much argument. They are constantly changing, especially when there is a change of government.

One of the most significant issues relating to trade unions today is the fall in membership. There are several reasons for this, but the most important one relates to the casualisation of the workforce.

The case for trade unions: Kerry

Kerry says that unions have been successful in bringing about higher wages and better working conditions for employees. She argues that people have a democratic right to get together as a group to fight for better wages and conditions. This provides protection for those workers who are new, young or inexperienced and don't know how to negotiate on their own for better conditions.

The case against trade unions: Chris

Chris claims that unions are too often guilty of causing inconvenience by taking strike actions that result in the disruption of public services. Furthermore, unions interfere too much in political issues instead of just dealing with issues directly related to the workers they represent. Chris feels that trade unions cause wages to rise too high and this creates more unemployment because employers cannot afford to hire extra workers.

Trade union membership: The facts

Australian Bureau of Statistics, August 2006

- One in five employees – 1.8 million people in Australia – are members of a trade union.
- Trade union membership fell by 6.6% in the 12 months to August 2006.
- 22% of full-time employees were trade union members, compared to 16% of part-time employees.
- 43% of public sector employees were trade union members, compared to 15% of private sector employees.
- 21% of male employees were trade union members compared to 19% of female employees.
- The occupation group with the highest proportion of employees who were trade union members was 'machinery operators and drivers' with 35%.
- The industries with the highest proportion of employees who were trade union members were 'electricity, gas, water and waste services' and 'education and training', both at 39%.
- The state or territory with the highest proportion of employees who were trade union members was Tasmania with 27%.

Activities

- 1 What is a trade union? What are its basic aims?
- 2 What do the letters ACTU stand for? When was this body formed? What is its main purpose?
- 3 What are the five reasons given by the ACTU for joining a trade union? Which one do you think is the most important? Why?
- 4 What labour organisations are there at the state level? What is their purpose?
- 5 Study the trade union membership facts.
 - a What was the percentage of trade union membership in 2006?
 - b How did it change from the previous 12 months?
 - c Why do you think it changed?
 - d Which specific group was most likely to hold trade union membership?
 - e Which occupations and which industries were best represented as trade union members? Suggest reasons for this.
- 6 What is meant by 'industrial relations policy'? Who sets it? Why is it so controversial?
- 7 Why are opinions about trade unions so strongly held?
- 8 Construct a table with the headings 'The case for trade unions' and 'The case against trade unions'. List as many points as you can under each heading.
- 9 What is Kerry's argument concerning trade unions?
- 10 How does Chris's argument differ from Kerry's argument? What is your view? Why?
- 11 Study the newspapers or use the Internet to search for current industrial relations disputes. What is the dispute about? Outline the two arguments in the dispute.



Individually or in groups, research a major industrial dispute in Australia's history. You could choose the Great Shearers' Strike of 1891, the pilots' dispute of 1989 or the Maritime Unions dispute of 1998. Each group could focus on a different dispute and afterwards compare what you found out.

3 Dealing with difficult workmates.....

Difficult and awkward situations always arise in the workplace. Some common ones are described below. The important thing is that you are aware when difficult situations crop up and know how to deal effectively with them.

The boss from hell

People in leadership positions often display vastly differing leadership styles. Some bosses lead by consensus and mutual cooperation and respect, while others have an autocratic leadership style, consulting nobody else, which can be intimidating. Yet others may be indecisive and muddled in their thinking, so that no real leadership takes place. You need to be aware of the many leadership styles and try to work harmoniously as part of the team. Leaders often project their own personality into the workplace and you may have no choice but to accept the type of boss you have. The term 'mutual respect' applies, no matter what style of leadership your boss uses.

It is important not to be too emotional or argumentative, but to try to manage situations sensibly. This could involve thinking before speaking, being diplomatic, or just trying to understand the situation. Of course, if the situation becomes intolerable and the boss begins personal abuse against you, then you may need to take the matter further.



Tony had a reputation for being a tough boss. He constantly abused his staff for their work output and their attitude. He would boast to his friends that the only way to get work out of people was to 'get stuck into them all the time' and to 'show that he was boss'.

What do you think?



The blocker

No matter what suggestions or innovations are made, the blocker is someone who will always find fault with an idea. They will say things like 'that's not how we do things here' or 'we have been doing it this way for the last 20 years'.

The best response to a blocker is to point out examples of technological progress which have occurred in recent years and how they have made a difference to efficiency and productivity in the workplace. It might also help to point out to a blocker what the price of bread was 20 years ago – in other words, we have moved on.

Ron had been with the company for 25 years. He was loyal and hard working, but always critical of new ideas. He would always say things were better before and there was no need for all this new-fangled technology stuff. Despite his loyalty he was becoming a problem for the company's future prospects.

What do you think?

The office relationship

It is inevitable that personal relationships will develop in workplaces. It is human nature for people to be physically and emotionally attracted to each other when working side by side.

Dealing with an 'office romance' can be tricky. You should treat your 'partner' in the same way you would if you were not romantically involved – in other words, just like other work colleagues. Giving special favours is never a good idea as it will be seen by others to be unfair.

Raphael and Jessica were working together on an important project for a large IT company. Before long they had fallen in love. Their supervisor, Joe Brash, was horrified and demanded that they immediately cease their relationship. Raphael and Jessica pleaded for leniency, saying that they tried not to let their feelings for each other affect their work output or their working relationship. Joe admitted that their work was fine but insisted that they should not be romantically linked.

What do you think?

The drama queen

Sometimes people – both females and males – bring all their personal problems to work and this can have a negative effect on the whole workplace, as listening to personal problems can distract people from their work tasks.

While it is probably all right to sympathise at first, it is probably best to stay out of the person's personal dramas, especially if they become stressful and affect the whole working environment. A better approach is to communicate with the drama queen only on work-related matters.

Cheryl was the office drama queen. She was always coming into work with some personal drama that just had to be talked about before anyone could settle down to work. At first her work mates were sympathetic and gave her advice. But there was always a new and different drama every Monday morning.

What do you think?

The workmate who gets promoted

Sometimes the transition from work colleague to supervisor can be difficult. The person who once mixed with office mates now finds that he or she has been promoted and the relationship changes. However, this need not be a problem if both sides understand the situation. Again, mutual respect for each worker's position should be mixed with mutual respect and friendship.

Mandy was promoted because she had impressed her supervisors with her drive and initiative as well as her general attitude and dedication to work. She was good friends with Julia and Terry but they soon became resentful that Mandy was the one chosen for promotion. They refused to have anything to do with Mandy from the time she took up her supervisor's role.

What do you think?

Activities

- 1 Why do difficult or awkward situations arise in a workplace?
- 2 What is meant by 'leadership styles'? Give examples of three different leadership styles and indicate which one you would prefer to use if you became a boss. Explain why.
- 3 Review the workplace scenarios to answer the following questions.
 - a What is your view of Joe Brash's attitude towards Raphael and Jessica?
 - b What advice would you give Raphael and Jessica if they approached you with their problem?
 - c What type of boss was Tony? Would you say he respected his workers? Should his workers be respected or should they only respect him?
 - d You work with Cheryl and one Monday morning she approaches you and starts complaining again about her mother and how she is affecting Cheryl's quality of life. What do you say to Cheryl? Would your response be any different if this was the first time Cheryl approached you?
 - e Why do you think Julia and Terry resent Mandy's promotion? What could Mandy do to ease the situation?
 - f You have been working with Ron on a project and you suggest an easier way of doing a task. Ron replies that he has been doing that task the same way for the last 25 years and what would you know about it? How would you reply to Ron? Is he entitled to be treated with respect?
- 4 Think of two more 'work types' different to the ones in this topic. Write a brief scenario about a person that fits each type, using the ones above as a model.
- 5 Explain what is meant by the term 'mutual respect'. Why is it important in every workplace as well as everyday life?



In groups, select one scenario from this topic. Act it out or prepare a written role play, showing how the scenario might be resolved.

Each group could select a different scenario and act it out in front of the class.

4 Casual employment pitfalls.....

Permanent or casual?

Permanent work usually involves regular, continuing employment. Casual work is more irregular and uncertain. Casual work is usually, though not always, part-time rather than full-time. Employers have no obligation to offer continuing work to a casual employee. However, this does not mean that casual workers are not protected in the workplace.

Sometimes an employer will hire contract workers to do a particular job. Contractors are different from casual employees in that they submit a quote for a job detailing the specifications and complete the job for a specific fee which is paid when the job is finished. For example, a builder may hire an electrician or a plumber to do specific tasks for an agreed price.

Typical casual work

Casual work is common among many groups of people, including those juggling work with study or childcare, those who can't find suitable full-time jobs and work two or even three casual jobs to make ends meet, and those who choose to avoid the strict routine of full-time work as a lifestyle choice. There has been an increase in the 'casualisation of the workforce' as casual work opportunities expand.

Advantages

Some of the benefits of casual work are listed below.

- It provides you with valuable work experience and helps you to develop transferable skills valued by employers.
- Part-time jobs provide you with some income and independence.
- It is a way to make new friends and develop networks.
- It offers flexibility and the possibility to work as much or as little as you want, when you want.
- For students from overseas countries it is a way to make new friends, become familiar with Australian work culture and improve English language skills.

Typical casual jobs

- waiter at a restaurant or café
- employee at a fast-food outlet
- shop assistant
- call-centre operator
- builder's labourer
- farm labourer
- fruit picker
- factory, assembly-line worker

The pitfalls

Maintaining a balance between work, study and leisure is very important. Working too many hours may have a negative effect on your education and neglecting leisure time can even affect your health. For most young people, priority needs to be given to education as it equips you for the future. Another issue is the income you earn. Casual work can be unreliable and it may not provide you with a regular income. This can become a problem if it is your only source of income, especially if you are supporting others financially. Casual and part-time workers are sometimes mistreated regarding the allocation of shifts, payment and basic conditions. Some things to watch out for are listed below.

- Employers who do not stick to required minimum standards in relation to record keeping, taxation, superannuation and OHS (Occupational Health & Safety), which all workers are entitled to.
- Shifts being cut without consultation or warning so you work less than you want to and need to. Your pay will be withheld for shifts that are cancelled, even if you did not want to cancel them.
- Shifts may be organised unfairly so that some people do all the unpopular times.
- You only get paid for the hours you work.
- You have no entitlement to paid leave/holidays, sick leave or other special forms of leave.
- Some employers will expect you to buy expensive uniforms or equipment.



- Casual workers are usually the first ones to be made redundant if the business has to reduce staff.
- Your employment might be terminated at any time, and this can often be when you reach a certain age or when you are due to be paid a higher rate.

Casual workers: rights and entitlements

Just because you are a casual worker does not mean you are not protected under government legislation. You should be aware of your rights and also your entitlements. For example, a casual employee is not entitled to annual leave, sick leave or paid for public holidays. However, in some cases casual employees are entitled to a proportionate amount of long service leave, unpaid parental leave and carer's leave. There may be additional leave entitlements if your position is covered by an award or agreement.

As a casual worker, you should not have to put up with inadequate conditions at work and you should not risk your own wellbeing. It is important to understand your rights and the terms and conditions you can expect in the workplace.

Further information about wages, conditions and entitlements:

- Workplace Authority provides information about wages and conditions of employment in Australia for work that is covered by Federal awards and agreements. www.workplaceauthority.gov.au
- The ACTU (Australian Council of Trade Unions) provides free advice about your rights at work. www.actu.asn.au
- The Office of the Workplace Ombudsman is an independent agency which provides information for employees and employers. www.wo.gov.au

What is required?

Many casual jobs require only basic skills. However, a positive attitude and a good work ethic are important. If an employer is concerned about a casual employee's attitude to their work, they can quite easily stop giving them further work or limit their work roster by reducing their hours.

Activities

- 1 What is the difference between casual employment and part-time employment?
- 2 How are casual employees generally paid? Explain how often and on what basis.
- 3 How do the working conditions of casual workers differ from those of permanent employees?
- 4 'Casual workers have no protection in the workplace.' Is this statement true or false? Explain.
- 5 What is meant by the term 'work ethic'? Why is it important to employers?
- 6 What is the difference between a casual employee and a contractor?
- 7 Describe some of the pitfalls that a casual worker might encounter. Which one do you think is the most serious? Why?
- 8 Is a casual worker entitled to sick leave or annual leave? Why do you think this is the case?
- 9 Are there any leave entitlements for casual workers? Explain.
- 10 What rights do casual workers have?
- 11 Check the websites listed above and briefly describe how each one can help casual workers to understand their rights and entitlements.



In groups, discuss the information provided on the websites listed above. Which website does your group think was the most useful? Why?

5 Keeping the CV up to date

It is important to keep your CV up to date, even if you currently hold a job. You may need it to apply for a promotion or a job opportunity that can further your career may suddenly come along. You may not realise it, but you do develop skills in the course of your work. You need to identify these skills and include them in your CV.

Who will read your CV?

You might assume that your CV is read by a person such as an employer or someone in the human resources department of an organisation. Increasingly, computers with special software are used to 'read' CVs to help sort through the huge numbers of applications that are submitted. These programs look for key words and phrases commonly used by the type of person that the employer wants. Once the computer does an initial sorting, the best CVs are read by people and analysed more closely.



What will impress the computer software

- ☒ competency statements
- ☒ simple structure, clear labels
- ☒ a concise CV, 2–3 pages

What will not impress the computer software

- ☒ tables, boxes, bullet points
- ☒ decorations, graphics, pictures
- ☒ a lengthy CV with lots of pages

What is a competency statement?

A competency statement can address an applicant's knowledge, skills, abilities and even attitudes. In a few short sentences, the applicant identifies a specific situation, explains what action was taken and the results of that action. Competency statements are extremely important in a CV as they tend to impress the reader.



Matching your skills to the job ad

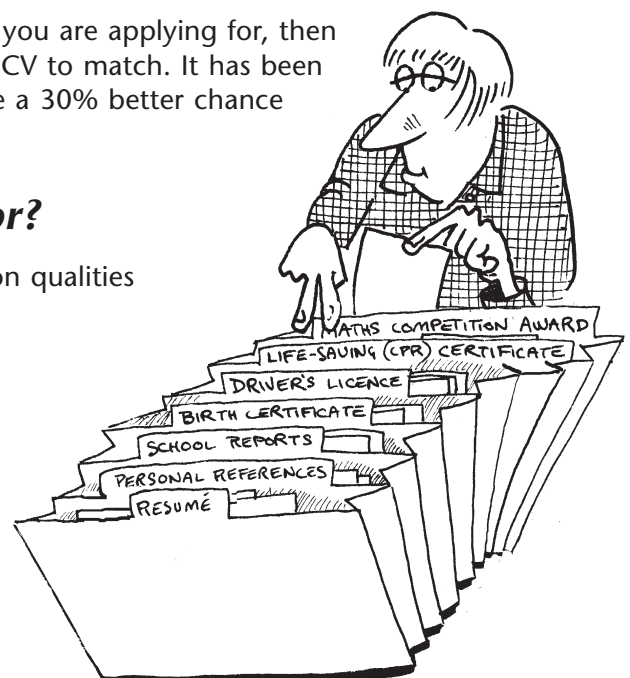
When reading a job ad, you need to analyse what skills the employer is likely to want. If the job is in finance and accounting, the skills required will obviously be a high degree of numerical reasoning ability, as well as attention to detail and diligence. These particular skills may not be so important if you applied for a job as an actor or circus performer – other skills would then come into play.

Once you have identified the skills required for the job you are applying for, then you need to organise your own particular skills in your CV to match. It has been found that applicants who can do this successfully have a 30% better chance of being shortlisted for a job.

What are employers really looking for?

Recent research has highlighted the eight most common qualities employers ask for in job ads:

- communication skills
- ability to work in a team
- attention to detail
- initiative
- energy
- ability to handle pressure
- enthusiasm
- leadership



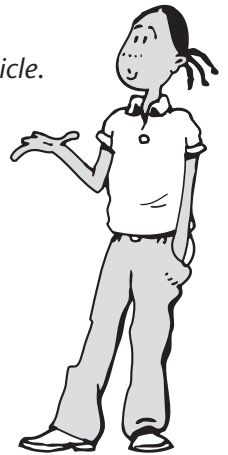
More hints

- Try to show links between what the employer wants and your personal strengths.
- Don't use a 'one size fits all' type of CV.
- Never just 'cut and paste' a CV from a website or a newspaper article. It will be obvious what you have done.
- Supply details of your employment history, including names and addresses of former employers and full job titles of your previous positions.
- Use the right words or 'jargon' of the industry. For example, if you are applying for a job in journalism, use words like *deadline*, *copy*, *editorial*, *byline* and *feature article*.

Sample extract from Aisha's CV

Special skills

- Typing course at Roundtown TAFE 2009. Competency tested at 40 wpm
- Basic computer skills. Access Internet, handle emails, word processing
- Proficient at using basic office equipment, photocopier, switchboard



Activities

- 1 Why is it important to keep your CV up to date even if you have a job?
- 2 How is it possible for a computer program to sift through CVs?
- 3 What would the computer program look for as it sorted through CVs? Why?
- 4 Why wouldn't the computer program be impressed with pictures, bullet points or boxes?
- 5 What is a 'competency statement'? Give an example.
- 6 What are the advantages of having a clear and concise structure to your CV?
- 7 Why do you think employers place high value on the communication skills of job applicants?
- 8 Explain the importance of qualities like initiative, energy and enthusiasm in a job. Give specific examples of the types of jobs where these qualities would be highly valued.
- 9 What is meant by the 'jargon' of an industry? Make a list of words that are included in the jargon of an industry other than journalism.
- 10 Explain the importance of matching your particular skills to a job ad.
- 11 What is the difference between a generic CV and a specially tailored CV?
- 12 In the extract of Aisha's CV above, what special skills did she display? What particular jobs might Aisha be suited for?



In groups, compile a list of all the different specific skills people have. Beside each skill, indicate what jobs might match these skills. Discuss any high order skills that could be useful for a particular job.

6 Interview skills in the workplace...

You have completed an interview for a job and been successful in gaining that job. Do you think there will be no more interviews? Then think again!

Interviews are now an integral part of the continuous assessment of a worker's progress in an organisation.

In other words, there are many other types of interviews apart from the initial job interview.

They include:

- annual reviews
- internal reviews
- disciplinary interviews
- internal promotion interviews.



Annual reviews are often used by companies or organisations to assess the performance of their employees each year. Employees are expected to participate openly and honestly in the process, and in return receive feedback from their manager or supervisor. This process is sometimes referred to as an Annual Performance Review. It is sometimes assessed against agreed goals or performance indicators. For example, a salesperson could need to demonstrate a specific sales target for the year.

Internal reviews are similar to annual reviews, except that they may occur more or less often and may be held for a specific purpose. For example:

- a new owner may wish to hold an internal review soon after taking over a business
- there may be a problem in the company or organisation, such as falling profits or evidence of fraud, which requires an internal review of performance.

Disciplinary interviews are held when an employee has done something which is either impolite, illegal or against the company or organisation's policies. They may involve a penalty, a demotion or a warning that future indiscretions will lead to instant dismissal.

Internal promotion interviews are a typical way of promoting employees to a higher position within the organisation. They may be one-on-one informal interviews or more formal, where the interview panel consists of three or more people.

Sarah's annual review interview

Sarah had worked at the XL Furniture Company for a year. She was called in for an annual review by her supervisor, Emily.

Emily: Well Sarah, you have been with us for a year now. How do you feel about working for this company?

Sarah: To be honest, I really enjoy my work here. I've made some good friends and had lots of help along the way, especially when I first started.

Emily: That's good. I've noticed that your attitude to work is very positive and that you have a good work ethic. Your personal dealings with customers have been excellent and your sales figures have reflected that.

Sarah: That's good to hear.

Emily: One thing I would suggest you consider is enrolling in an advanced sales course at TAFE to further develop your selling techniques. We can give you some time off to do the course.

Sarah: Yes, I would like to do that. I really want to succeed in this business.

Emily: Well, you have the ability and the right attitude. With more experience and an upgrade of your qualifications, who knows where it might lead?

Sarah: Thank you Emily for your advice and feedback.



Interview tips

The same general advice applies for these types of interviews as for a job interview.

- Be open and honest.
- Consider your body language (shake hands, make eye contact, smile).
- Be positive.
- Be polite.
- Take care with your appearance.
- Be well prepared. Anticipate likely questions and rehearse them with a friend.



Activities

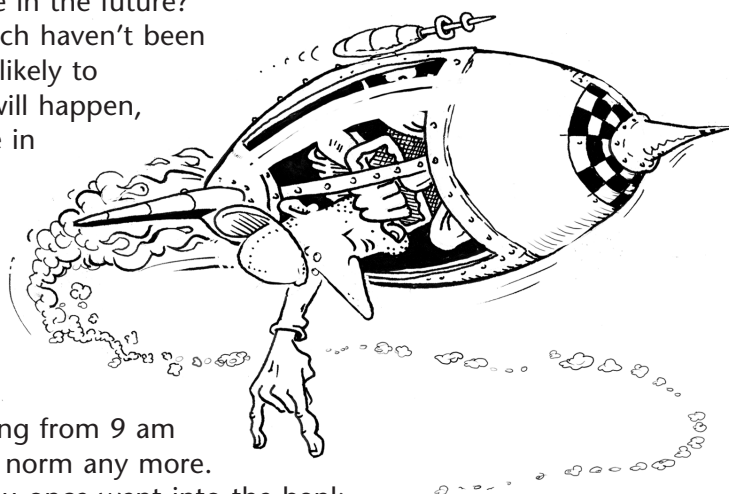
- 1 Why is it a good idea to constantly work on and improve your interview skills?
- 2 Make a list of the types of interviews you may experience in your job, or in a job you would like to have. Should your approach be different, depending on which type of interview you are preparing for?
- 3 What is the purpose of an Annual Performance Review? Who normally conducts it?
- 4 Your friend and work colleague Lachlan has been caught stealing stationery from the company. He has been called in for a disciplinary interview, and has come to you for advice. What advice would you give him for preparing for his interview?
- 5 What is meant by the term 'body language'? Give examples of good and bad body language in an interview situation.
- 6 Why is your appearance important in an interview?
- 7 Should you ever go to an interview unprepared? Why? How can you prepare for an interview if you don't know the questions that will be asked?
- 8 Read Sarah's interview with Emily.
 - a Why was Sarah interviewed?
 - b Who was Emily? What was her task?
 - c Was the interview a positive experience for Sarah? Why?
 - d What advice was Sarah given? How might this advice help her?
 - e How important do you think Sarah's positive attitude to work was to Emily? Explain your answer.
- 9 Using Sarah's interview as a model, write another interview scenario where Emily is interviewing Nathan, an employee whose attitude and work performance is less positive than Sarah's.
- 10 Is an interview the only way to assess an employee's success at work? What other methods could be used?



Working in pairs, roleplay the different types of interviews described in this topic. Take turns at the roles of supervisor and employee.

7 Work in the future

Have you ever wondered what work will be like in the future? There will probably be many jobs available which haven't been invented yet, and many jobs once popular are likely to disappear. This makes it hard to predict what will happen, but it is wise to be aware of the rate of change in our society in general – much of this change is driven by new technology. You only have to look at car manufacturing in today's world to see how automated some industries have become. Modern communication technologies, especially the Internet, have also revolutionised the nature of work.



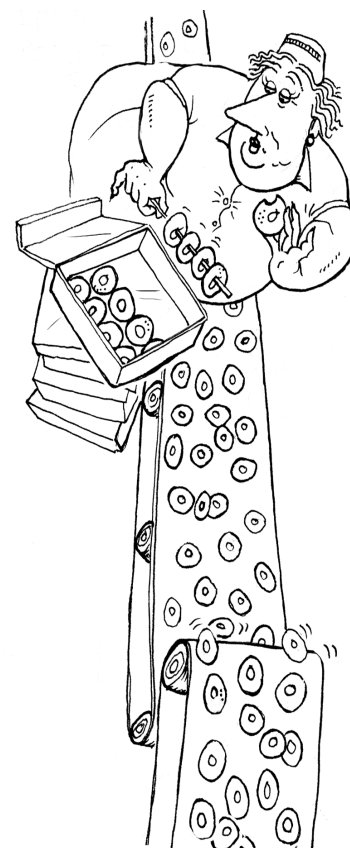
Workplaces are likely to be different too. Working from 9 am to 5 pm in an office or factory may not be the norm any more.

For example, to borrow money from a bank you once went into the bank branch near you and made an appointment with the manager. Today it is common for bank employees to come to your house with a laptop computer loaded with financial software and talk about your loan application, which you could have submitted online.

Some of the many changes that have occurred in the workplace in recent years are listed below.

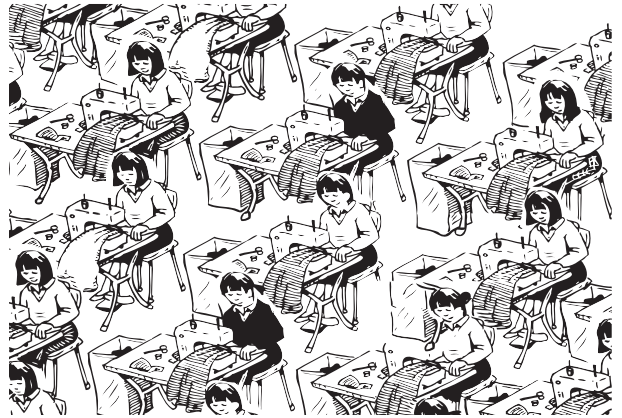
Workplace changes

- ☒ Greater use of technology, such as computers and telecommunications equipment
- ☒ Gradual elimination of unskilled work, which is increasingly done by machines
- ☒ Increase in the importance of on-the-job training and higher qualifications
- ☒ Skilled tradespeople in danger of losing their jobs due to complex computerised machinery replacing them, leading to de-skilling
- ☒ A greater variety of jobs available, especially in the service sector
- ☒ Greater job mobility with increased chances of working overseas
- ☒ The concept of a 'job for life' which was once the norm, is becoming less common
- ☒ An increase in the percentage of part-time workers compared to full-time workers
- ☒ An increase in the hours worked by full-time workers
- ☒ An increase in casual work and contract work
- ☒ Changing gender roles, with more women taking up professional occupations and those traditionally done only by men
- ☒ Greater flexibility of working hours and conditions, such as flexi-time and rostered days off
- ☒ An increase in the number of people who work from home
- ☒ More profit sharing between company owners and workers or pay incentives to achieve work targets
- ☒ A decrease in the number of workers in 'middle management' – the result of firms downsizing
- ☒ Increasing consideration for disadvantaged groups in the workforce, including people with disabilities.



Work issues of the future

Are these workplace changes likely to continue or to occur more rapidly? Will the workers of the future be just out-sourced, self-employed contractors? Will the influence of the trade unions be further reduced or will there be a revival in the value placed on people cooperating to defend their rights and working conditions? It is hard to guess the answers to these questions, but the issues raised by them and the possible effects on society will be debated at length, well into the future.



Activities

- 1 How has the increasing use of technology changed the workplace? Give examples.
- 2 Why is the number of unskilled jobs decreasing?
- 3 What is meant by 'de-skilling'? How does it happen? What can be done about it?
- 4 What is meant by 'greater flexibility in the workplace'? Give examples.
- 5 What is 'downsizing'? Why is it sometimes necessary?
- 6 Why do you think on-the-job training is becoming more important?
- 7 Why is having a 'job-for-life' becoming less common?
- 8 What types of incentives are now being offered to some workers?
- 9 Megan is a highly trained specialist in IT (Information Technology). She has a very good job with an IT company but she feels she wants more experience. What options do you think Megan has for widening her experience?
- 10 Consider the list of workplace changes. Choose one change, and decide whether it is a positive change or a negative change. Give reasons for your answer.
- 11 Think of a job you would like to do. What effects do you think the workplace changes will have on this job?
- 12 List five jobs you think won't exist anymore in 20 years.
- 13 List five jobs that don't exist today that you think will exist in 20 years.



- Design a typical office for the year 2050.
- Hold a class debate about the issues associated with the following statements:
 - In the future, workers will be just out-sourced, self-employed contractors.
 - In the future, trade unions will experience a period of renewed growth.

8 Workplace behaviour: bullying.....

Bullying is often seen as something that happens in the schoolyard rather than the workplace. Yet it has been found that over one million Australians are bullied at work every year. A significant number of people are subjected to long-term bullying.

What is bullying behaviour?

There are several aspects of behaviour that can be regarded as bullying. This is not a complete list, but bullying can include the following behaviours.



shouting
and yelling

constant
criticism

setting
impossible
deadlines

inappropriate
comments about a
worker's personal
appearance



spreading rumours
about someone

teasing

'rites of passage' or 'initiation' behaviours, such as abusing or playing hurtful tricks on young workers or new employees.

The excuse given for this type of behaviour is that is what all new employees have to put up with, it is part of the system

It is important to understand the difference between bullying and a personality clash. With a personality clash, both people involved may develop a dislike for each other and engage in some form of mutual verbal abuse. A personality clash may only flare up once and then the people may agree to disagree or simply try to avoid each other.

On the other hand, bullying tends to be one-sided, in a situation where there is a power or status difference between the bully and the victim. Bullying behaviour is usually repeated, sometimes over a long period of time. It may be a series of incidents, each of which seems minor at the time, but when considered altogether they constitute unacceptable bullying.

Workplace bullies can be:

- male or female
- people who feel insecure
- people who were bullied themselves in the past
- people who are frustrated by their own lack of progress in the workplace
- people affected by pressure in the workplace.

The following two case studies illustrate aspects of workplace bullying. The second case study is a true story.

Shelley was a supervisor at Zipfast, a large interstate transport company. She was responsible for organising the drivers' rosters. One Friday morning she asked Adam, a new employee at the company, to provide her with a list of all the pick-up locations from the past twelve months, including addresses and other contact details. She wanted that information at 5 pm that day. When Adam questioned whether he could get that job done in time, Shelley turned on him and shouted, 'Are you stupid or something? Just get it done and that's an order.'

Promptly at 5 pm, Adam presented Shelley with a list but it was incomplete. He said he was sorry but completing the task would take much longer than the time allowed. He also said that he needed help to do the job properly. Shelley immediately started screaming again, saying that it had to be done before he knocked off work for the weekend.



A young apprentice had been subjected to ongoing teasing for the amusement of the other more experienced employees. They made fun of him and humiliated him every day. A number of incidents could actually be classified as assault. The apprentice was put in a 44 gallon drum and the drum was rolled down a hill. On another occasion he was hung upside down from the ceiling in a harness and a fire was lit under him. The apprentice became extremely distressed and traumatised by his workplace experiences.

At a court hearing, it was discovered that in this workplace there had been a culture of intimidation and that it was normal practice for a junior employee to be bullied. The employer was forced to pay a substantial sum of money as compensation to the apprentice. The employer was also criticised by the court for not seeing the consequences of this failure to wipe out bullying behaviour.

Dealing with bullying

- You don't have to put up with it.
- See someone in charge whom you trust and register your complaint.
- You have certain rights under bodies such as the Equal Employment Opportunity Commission and the Anti-discrimination Commission.

Activities

- 1 Is bullying a problem in the workplace? Explain.
- 2 Consider the diagram that lists aspects of behaviour that constitute bullying. List them in order from most serious to least serious. Give reasons for the order you chose.
- 3 Explain how bullying is different from a personality clash.
- 4 Mark each statement as true or false.
 - a All bullying is carried out by males.
 - b Bullies are often seen to be insecure.
 - c Bullying is mostly done by more experienced employees.
 - d Bullying can occur over a long period.
 - e There is nothing an employee can do about bullying.
- 5 Review the story of Shelley and Adam.
 - a Was Shelley guilty of bullying? Explain the reason for your answer.
 - b Was Shelley's demand reasonable? Explain.
 - c Was there anything wrong with Adam's behaviour?
 - d What do you think was the cause of the problem? How could it have been avoided?
 - e Assume Adam made a complaint about Shelley to the boss in charge. If you were Adam, what arguments would you present in your complaint?
 - f Imagine you are the boss. What would you say to Adam after hearing his complaint? What would you later say to Shelley?
- 6 Refer to the story of the young apprentice.
 - a Describe the nature of the bullying in this case.
 - b What was the employer's attitude to this type of behaviour?
 - c What is your view of this type of behaviour?
 - d How was the situation resolved?
- 7 What action should a worker take if he or she is being bullied?



In groups, discuss specific cases of bullying that you have witnessed or heard about. Consider the differences between workplace bullying and schoolyard bullying in your discussion. Prepare a brief presentation for other groups that summarises the results of your discussions.

9 Skills required for specific jobs.....

Nobody is completely unskilled. Everyone has skills of some sort or another, but perhaps they are not aware of them. In fact, people have skills which can be related to one or more occupations. Many skills are transferable, which means they can be used in a variety of occupations. Interpersonal skills such as being able to relate to other people and to communicate effectively are very important in almost any job.

It is useful to complete a systematic analysis of your skills, and the skills you already have should be listed in your resume or CV. And you need to update them as you accumulate more skills.

Job-specific skills

There are some skills which are specific to particular jobs. For the position of typist, an applicant is expected to be able to type. Not only that, but to have reached a certain standard such as 50 words per minute. The skills required of a doctor are very different from those required of a carpenter or a computer operator.

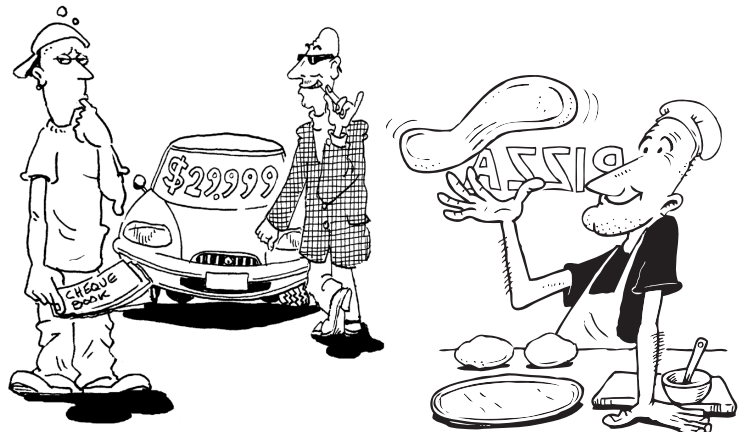
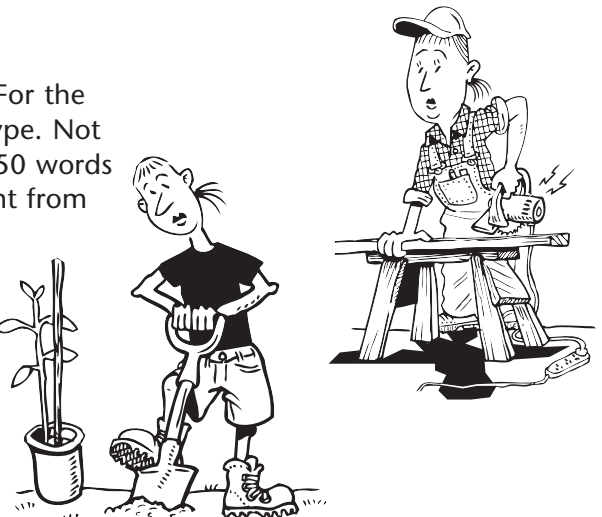
While there are some skills that are relevant to all jobs, when you are choosing a career path, you need to assess your own particular skills and abilities as well as your academic performance. For example, a doctor not only needs very specialised skills but also a very high academic performance.

When choosing a career, assess three basic things:

- 1 your skills and abilities
- 2 your academic performance
- 3 your interests.

Being interested is very important as you will always learn more effectively if you are interested in something. Many people get persuaded into careers that they are not interested in, even though they may have the academic qualifications and the skills required.

Below is a list of specific skills which may be required for certain jobs.



Specific skills

- | | | | |
|----------------------|-------------------------------|---------------------------------|-----------------------------|
| ➤ data entry | ➤ selling or marketing | ➤ telephone-answering technique | ➤ driving a tractor |
| ➤ typing | ➤ reading | ➤ public speaking | ➤ creative thinking |
| ➤ filing | ➤ editing | ➤ cooking | ➤ singing |
| ➤ cleaning | ➤ creative writing | ➤ using a computer | ➤ keeping financial records |
| ➤ repairing things | ➤ stocktaking | ➤ acting | ➤ flying a plane |
| ➤ photography | ➤ bricklaying | ➤ playing a musical instrument | ➤ caring for others |
| ➤ drawing | ➤ diagnosing medical problems | ➤ serving meals | ➤ first aid |
| ➤ designing | ➤ investigating | ➤ interviewing people | |
| ➤ desktop publishing | ➤ dancing | | |

Transferable skills

These are skills that are useful in many job situations. For example, employers often ask for good communication skills. They also want people with good reading and writing skills, people with mathematical skills and people who are computer literate. On the next page is a list of some important transferable skills.

Transferable skills

- ➔ synthesise data and concepts
- ➔ analyse data
- ➔ make decisions
- ➔ identify problems and provide solutions
- ➔ listen to instructions and follow directions
- ➔ work independently
- ➔ observe and evaluate situations and/or people
- ➔ persuade and lead
- ➔ delegate tasks to others
- ➔ plan and organise projects and/or people
- ➔ assess the performance of others
- ➔ train others



Ethan had left school having completed his Higher School Certificate but with no idea what career he wanted to follow. He had worked as a builder's labourer in the Christmas holidays for the past two years but was certain that he didn't want to pursue a career in building. He had done well in Visual Arts at school and loved drawing. He was also very skilled in computer graphics. He was polite and well mannered and had many friends. He played guitar reasonably well and was a good school debater. Ethan needed some help in working out what career opportunities would match his skills and interests.

Activities

- 1 Do all school leavers have skills of some description? Explain.
- 2 Why is it useful to identify and analyse your skills? Should you record them? Where and why?
- 3 What is meant by 'interpersonal skills'? What specific skills are included in this category? How important are they in any job?
- 4 What is meant by 'job-specific skills'? Give an example.
- 5 Study the list of transferable skills. Make a list of the transferable skills you believe you have now.
- 6 Think of a job you are interested in.
 - a List the transferable skills you think would be useful in this job.
 - b How could you gain the transferable skills you do not already have?
- 7 Study the list of specific skills. Identify the skills you believe would be necessary for success in the following jobs. You can choose as many skills as you wish and you can use a skill more than once.

- | | | |
|--------------------------------|-----------------------------|---------------------------------|
| a a chef | f a flight attendant | k a doctor |
| b an actor | g an author | l a plumber |
| c a farmer | h a nurse | m a salesperson |
| d a pilot | i a builder | n a call-centre operator |
| e a computer programmer | j a journalist | o a solicitor |

- 8 Refer to the story of Ethan.
 - a What specific skills does Ethan possess?
 - b What type of career do you think would suit Ethan's particular skills?
 - c What specific occupations do you think Ethan should consider?
 - d What advice would you give Ethan to help him with this decision? Where could he go for help?



Search the newspapers for specific job ads which you believe would suit your particular skills. Make a collage of them and share this information with a group. Gain the group's feedback on your skills analysis.

10 Work environments: etiquette.....

You can come across some tricky situations in the workplace. How do you address the boss, or your immediate supervisor? What should you be careful to avoid?

Workplace etiquette – hints

- ✓ Be interested and interesting.
- ✓ Don't eat other people's lunch.
- ✓ Clean up after yourself (wash out your own coffee mug).
- ✓ Don't complain about other work colleagues – say nothing about anyone that you wouldn't say to them.
- ✓ Dress neatly and appropriately to suit the occasion or the work situation.
- ✓ Watch your manners.
- ✓ Learn how to address people.
- ✓ Consider correct mobile phone etiquette in the workplace.
- ✓ Don't make improper use of computers at work, such as writing personal emails or using the Internet for personal use.
- ✓ Take care with email language, as attempts at humour can backfire. Always read through an email after you have written it, before you click the send button.
- ✓ Watch your personal behaviour at social functions, especially the office Christmas party.
- ✓ Consider the unwritten rules in the workplace, as well as the written ones.



Sam's first day

Sam: So you're gonna be my supervisor for this crazy new job I've just landed. Well Jane, it's a pleasure working for you. I hope we get to be real friendly. By the way, I like a drink after work. Would love to buy you one this afternoon if you're free. How about it?

Jane: Sam, my name is Ms Robinson and I think you should address me at work as Ms Robinson. As for having a drink after work this afternoon I think it is a bit premature at this stage. After all, this is your first day on the job. Perhaps we can mix socially when we all go down for a drink on the first Friday of the month. We all put \$10 a week into a social club fund and use the money for that purpose.

Sam: Sure, but I'd like to get to know you better. That would be real cool. So how about that drink this arvo?

Jane: I'm sorry, but it is not appropriate at this stage.

Sam: (under his breath) Spoil sport.



Sam's work situation after six weeks

Jane: Sam, I'd like to talk to you about your progress at work over the last six weeks.

Sam: Sure Jane, er, I mean Ms Robinson. What's the go?

Jane: Well Sam, your work progress is quite good. You have mastered some tricky skills that are needed in a job like yours. But I am more concerned about your personal behaviour. You are a little too over familiar with people who are senior to you. Also, your appearance could be improved. Dirty jeans and thongs are not proper clothing for an office job. I have also received complaints that you don't clean up your lunch dishes or wash out your coffee mug after using it. You know that it is office policy for everyone to clean up after themselves.

Sam: Listen Jane, I'm too busy to wash up. My job is important and people rely on me to perform. I think you are being unfair. And also a bit stuck up, since you won't have a drink with me.

Jane: Sam, I think you have a lot to learn about workplace etiquette.

Sam: What's that?

Activities

- 1 What is meant by 'be interested and interesting'? How are these two things different? Give examples.
- 2 Sam is a work colleague of yours and has an annoying habit of not cleaning up his lunch dishes and not washing out his coffee mug. Which of these responses displays the most appropriate work etiquette?
 - A Ignore Sam's behaviour.
 - B Get stuck into Sam and say he is a loser.
 - C Dob Sam into Ms Jane Robinson, the supervisor.
 - D Tell Sam that it would be appreciated if he cleaned up after himself as that is the fair thing to do.
- 3 Why is it important to avoid complaining about or criticising work colleagues?
- 4 If you have a grievance against a work colleague, what should you do? Why?
- 5 Should you call a work colleague who is senior to you by their surname (e.g. Mr Smith)? When is it appropriate to call them by their first name?
- 6 Refer to Sam's work scenarios.
 - a What aspects of Sam's behaviour do you consider inappropriate for his first day at work? Why?
 - b What is your view of Jane Robinson's attitude to Sam on the first day?
 - c What is your view of Jane Robinson's approach to Sam after six weeks?
 - d What were Sam's shortcomings in his personal behaviour?
 - e Is Sam's behaviour justified if it is shown that his work is up to standard?
 - f If you were Jane Robinson, how would you explain to Sam what office etiquette is?
- 7 What is so significant about the office Christmas party? What dangers are there for inexperienced workers at their first office Christmas party?
- 8 If you were Jane Robinson and found that Sam was making personal calls, sending personal emails and using the Internet for personal reasons, what would you say to him?
- 9 Are there circumstances when making a personal call or sending a personal email in office hours is acceptable? Give an example.



In groups, discuss some of the tricky workplace situations that can arise. You may be able to talk from personal experience or have friends or family who have encountered problems. Make a group list of the most common problems for display.

11 Work environments: cultural issues

Multicultural issues

When you begin a new job you'll probably find yourself working with people of different racial backgrounds and religions. Their cultures may seem foreign to you, and your culture may be equally foreign to them. Recognition and respect for other people's cultural beliefs is an important part of working harmoniously in a workplace.

Here are some comments you may well hear in a workplace. What do you think?

- *'I don't like working with Asians.'*
- *'Yes, but he's a Christian.'*
- *'Ahmed is from Iraq you know. What can you expect from a fellow with that background?'*
- *'I don't want to be supervised by a Serbian.'*



Gender issues

Women and men should be treated equally in the workplace. It has now been decades since it was socially acceptable to treat women as being inferior to men. Women were once paid less, discriminated against and often passed over for promotion. Even today, women talk of the 'glass ceiling' when it comes to promotion prospects.

Despite the equal treatment you may hear these comments in the workplace.

- *'That's a woman's job.'*
- *'You get the women to make the morning tea so the men can do the important work.'*
- *'Oh, don't promote her. Now that she's married she'll only get pregnant and leave – and you'll have to pay her maternity leave, you know.'*

Disabled workers

In the past, people who suffered a disability, no matter how severe, were not welcome in the workplace. During the 1950s, parents of people with disabilities set up sheltered workshops to provide employment for their children. Some voluntary organisations also opened workshops. Today that situation is no longer acceptable. People with mild disabilities are accepted and encouraged to join the workforce and employers are obliged to provide them with opportunities and facilities to assist them as needed. Expectations of work output are often adjusted to allow for disabilities, but rather than have sheltered workshops, integration in the workforce is the goal.

All governments at every level in Australia as well as private organisations work together to ensure equal employment opportunities for people with disabilities. Some people with disabilities may require support or assistance to find an appropriate form of employment.

Assistance is available to:

- help determine job interests and suitable types of employment
- search for relevant jobs
- prepare for job interviews
- help with understanding employment conditions
- provide ongoing support.

People with more severe disabilities may require more intensive support and some organisations provide this. Whatever the disability, making sure that wherever possible the workplace is accessible for employees with disabilities is a responsibility of all employers. Attitudes to working with people with disabilities are unfortunately still varied. You may hear comments like the following.

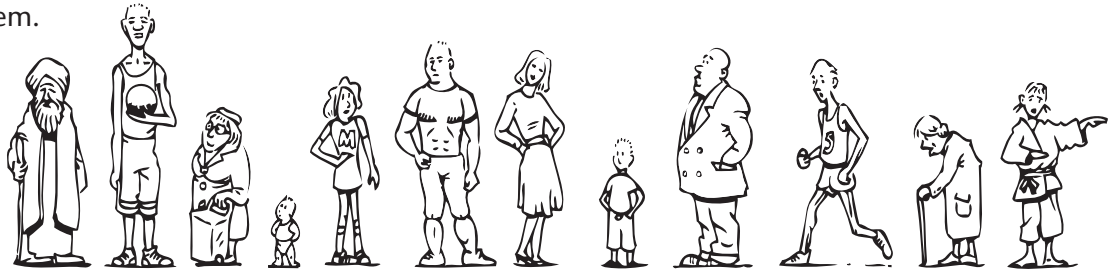
Jonah: I can't work with him, he's so slow.

Miriam: But do you realise he has a disability? Give him a chance. How would you like to be discriminated against and have nobody prepared to employ you?

Anti-discrimination laws

Discrimination means treating people unfairly on the basis of some prejudice. Therefore, workers should not be discriminated against on the basis of their age, sex, race, religion or disability. In fact, it is now against the law to discriminate against any worker by:

- refusing to employ them
- preventing them from being promoted
- giving them less favourable conditions of employment
- dismissing them.



Activities

- 1 What is meant by 'a multicultural workforce'?
- 2 Explain why each comment is discriminatory.
 - a 'I'm not employing Noah, he's gay'.
 - b 'I refuse to work with women.'
 - c 'Men are hopeless. I am not going to promote any men in my team'.
 - d 'He's over 70 – obviously too old to get the job.'
 - e 'Let's just employ Catholics. At least we know where we stand with them.'
 - f 'I'm only working with Australians. They know what they're doing.'
- 3 Why is it unfair to criticise people in the workplace simply because of their race?
- 4 Read the comments on the previous page which indicate racist attitudes. For each one, write what your response would be if you heard them said in your workplace. Remember, workplace etiquette requires you to be morally responsible **and** polite.
- 5 Suggest why women were once discriminated against in the workplace. How and why has that changed? Has it completely changed everywhere? Explain.
- 6 Read the comments which indicate a sexist attitude to working with women. For each one, write what your response would be if you heard them said in your workplace.
- 7 How has the treatment of disabled workers changed in recent years? Suggest why it was decided that sheltered workshops are not the answer.
- 8 How are disabled workers assisted with their integration into the workforce?
- 9 What was Jonah's attitude to working with a disabled person? What was Miriam's attitude?
- 10 What are anti-discrimination laws? Whom do they protect?
- 11 Read the discriminatory comments. For each one, write what your response would be if you heard them said in your workplace.



In groups, conduct a roleplay to illustrate anti-discriminatory behaviour in the workplace. The roleplay can be scripted first or improvised. Afterwards, discuss what you learned.

12 Workplace communication.....

The importance of communication

Communication is basic to all aspects of modern life and therefore important in every job. The quality or level of communication required depends on the nature of the job, and how much interaction with the public and other work colleagues is required.

There are two basic types of communication:

- verbal – involves speaking skills and listening skills
- written – involves writing letters, reports, articles, summaries, emails and notes.

Definition: Communication is the interchange of ideas, facts and opinions. It involves receiving and understanding information from others, and providing information to others in a way that can be easily understood.

Verbal skills

Verbal skills include speaking skills. This means:

- speaking clearly
- speaking with confidence
- analysing your thoughts and putting them into words
- using correct grammar.

Listening skills are just as important. A person with well developed verbal communication skills needs to be a good listener. This means concentrating on what is being said by the person speaking to you and analysing what their message is.



Written skills

Communicating in writing has two pitfalls which verbal communication doesn't:

- spelling
- grammar.

While it is now becoming commonplace to abbreviate words and use a special 'mobile phone, SMS' language in emails, there are many occasions when formal writing is necessary. Different types of formal writing have different guidelines and layout requirements.



Writing letters

A business letter should have:

- the address of the sender at top left or top right
- the date, at top left or top right
- a salutation, such as Dear Sir, Dear Madam, Dear Mr Jones
- correct spelling
- correct grammar
- formal English – written in complete sentences with no abbreviations
- an appropriate ending, such as 'Yours faithfully' or 'Yours sincerely' if the person is known to you.



Writing reports or articles

Formal English is again necessary in these forms of written communication. Complete sentences should be used, with no abbreviations or colloquial (slang) language.

Writing notes or emails

These forms of written communication are in some circumstances just as important as reports and articles. However, informal language is generally acceptable in emails and notes.

Notes from a meeting can contain abbreviations to save time and to make sure everything is taken down, especially if you are making notes from a lecture or speech. Similarly, emails have developed a language of their own, without formal salutations and with the widespread use of abbreviations. Some people even ignore capital letters and punctuation in emails, and include emoticons. There may be an email policy in a particular workplace. Emails are still a written form of communication and can be used by others as proof that communication did take place. Some workplaces require emails to be written in more formal language.

Sharing your opinions

There may be situations in your work where you are required to give your opinions. This requires some thought because you may also have to give reasons and explanations for your opinions. There is no need to be nervous about giving your opinion, but it is important to be prepared. Remember that confidence and preparation are the keys to successful verbal communication. There is no point getting aggravated or aggressive if your opinions are questioned. Using logical reasons communicated clearly is generally the most effective way of convincing others.

Activities

- 1 Write a definition of communication in your own words. Include specific examples.
- 2 Explain why good communication is necessary in the workplace.
- 3 What are the main components of verbal communication? Give examples of each one.
- 4 Read the following report extract. Rewrite it using correct spelling and grammar.

The future prospects of the company is basically sound there are plenty of opportunities for growth me and the managing director believe we have the skills and expertise to succeed. If youse could all submit your suggestions to Mr Jones and I for perusal that'd be bonza.

- 5 Why are letter-writing skills important in the workplace?
- 6 What advantages do formal documents have over emails?
- 7 Write out the following 'email-style' abbreviations in full.

a YRUL8	c THNKS	e EZY2C	g WDYT	i YOYO
b CUL8R	d 2MORO	f GR8	h OIC	j B4

- 8 List three other email or SMS abbreviations you know.
- 9 You work with Lyn and she has just come to you in tears to say that her PowerPoint presentation to her work colleagues was strongly criticised. She has been asked to make her presentation again in a week's time. What advice would you offer Lyn?
- 10 What makes a good listener? Are listening skills just as important as speaking skills? Explain.
- 11 You work for a travel agency. Write a formal letter to the sales manager of a large tour company, Extreme Tours Ltd, requesting their latest brochures. Also ask for any other information that might help you sell their travel packages.



In groups, make a list of common communication problems. Discuss the circumstances under which communication can break down. How can these breakdowns in communication be avoided?

13 Types of management structures

When you start work in a new organisation it is important to know a little about its management structure. You need to know such things as:

- who does what
- who reports to whom
- who is responsible for whom
- how to communicate any complaints, concerns or requests for assistance.

The organisation may be either government or private, large or small. Whatever the size and nature of the organisation, they have some things in common. The following diagrams will show you typical management structures.

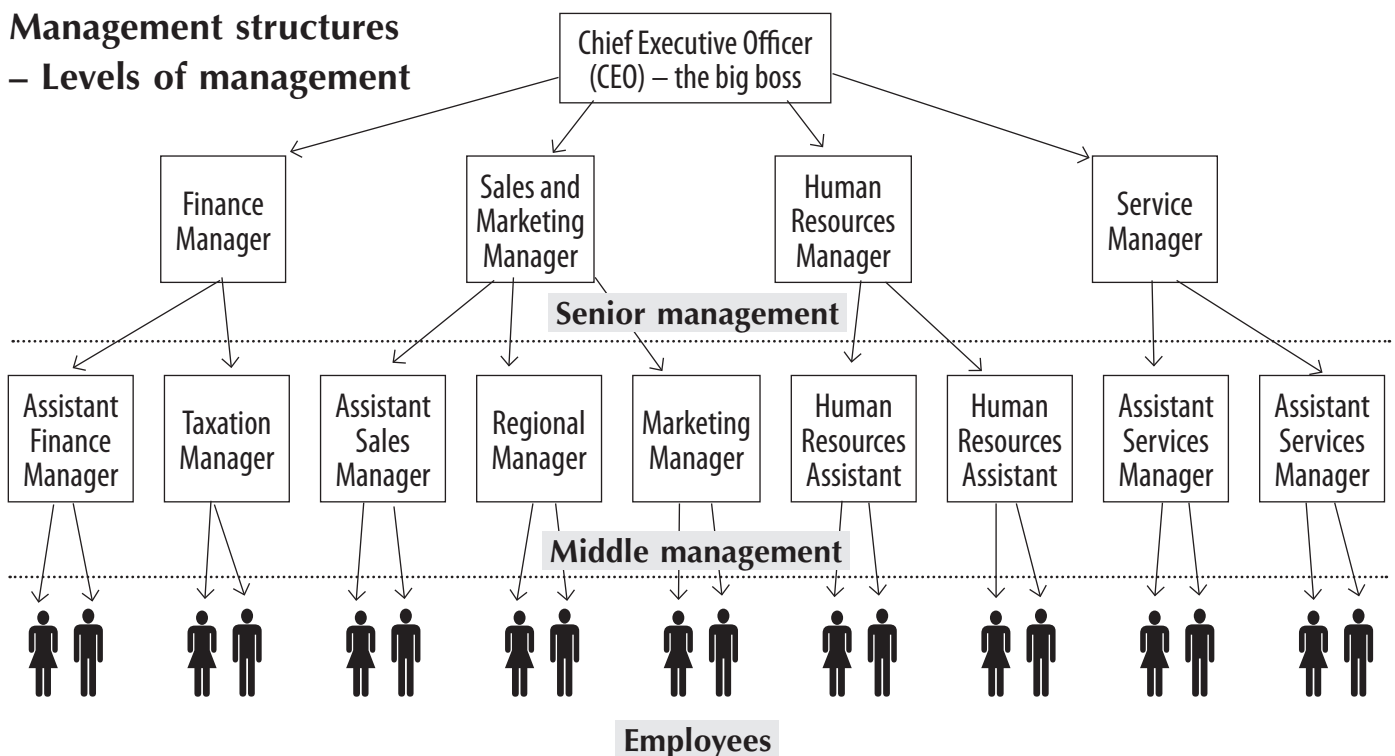
Types of businesses

Businesses may be small or large, but they can also differ according to ownership:

- **Sole trader** – A business with one owner that is usually small in size. Common examples of sole traders are a corner store owner, an electrician, a plumber, a hairdresser and a café owner.
- **Partnership** – A business owned by two or more people. It can have up to 20 owners, but usually two, three or four joint owners. Typical partnerships include law firms, doctors, dentists, financial advisors and building contractors. Sole traders and partnerships both have unlimited liability. That is, they are responsible for all the business debts and also receive all the profits.
- **Companies** – A business owned by shareholders who have a limited liability; they are liable only to the value of the shares they purchased. Companies may be private, where shareholders are invited to buy shares, or public companies which are listed on the Stock Exchange where anyone can buy shares. Companies are controlled by a Board of Directors and the Directors are responsible to the shareholders. Generally, the Board of Directors will appoint a person to manage the business on a day-to-day basis. This person is generally referred to as the Chief Executive Officer (CEO), and is responsible to the Board of Directors.

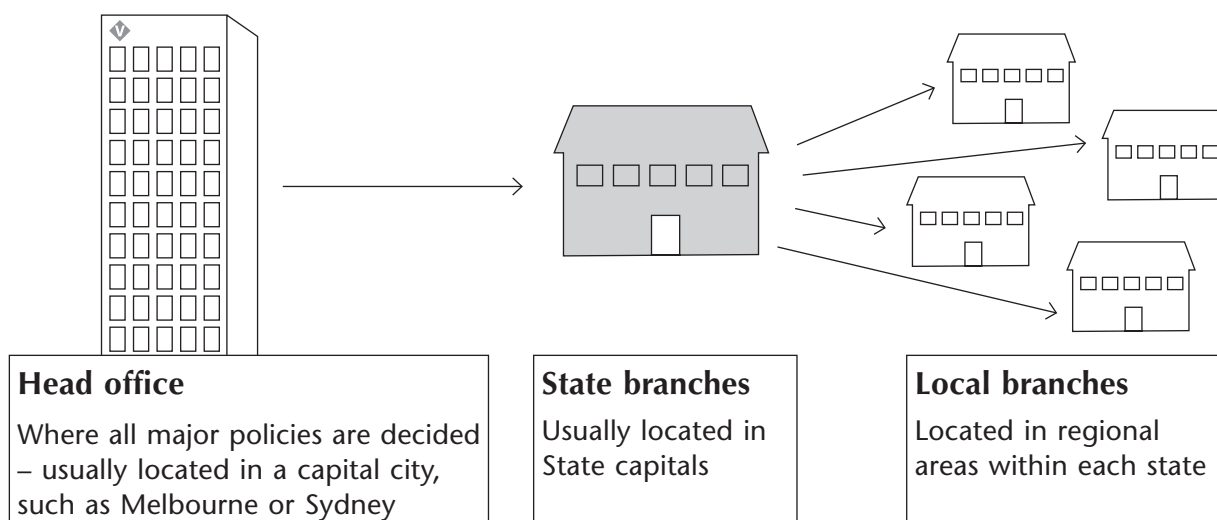
Management structures

– Levels of management



- The arrows indicate the lines of responsibility, who reports to whom and who assesses the work of others.
- Employees who have problems are expected to report them to their immediate supervisor, which is the reverse of the arrow direction.

Hierarchy of workplaces



Examples: Major banks, government departments, large companies, e.g. Woolworths

Activities

- 1 Why is it important to understand a little about the management structure of your workplace?
- 2 A workplace may be large or small. Give two examples of small workplaces and two examples of large workplaces.
- 3 Describe the differences between the three different types of businesses, according to ownership. What is meant by limited liability?
- 4 What is the correct title for the boss of a large company?
- 5 Who is the boss of a large company responsible to?
- 6 Refer to the diagrams showing the hierarchy of workplaces and levels of management.
 - a Where is the head office of a large organisation normally located? Why?
 - b Where would state branches most likely be located? Why?
 - c Why might some organisations have local branches?
 - d Where is company policy decided?
 - e Why is it important to understand the hierarchy of an organisation if you are working in one?
 - f Give examples of senior management positions in a large organisation or company.
 - g Is there a need for middle management positions in a large company? Give examples.
 - h How do these diagrams explain how an employee would go about reporting a problem?
 - i How do these diagrams explain the lines of responsibility in an organisation?



In groups, examine the management structure of a large company or organisation. For example, you could examine the company structure of a large retailer, such as Woolworths or Harvey Norman, an airline like QANTAS or a government department such as the Department of Foreign Affairs and Trade. Examine two or more examples. How are they different? What do they have in common?

14 Unfair and fair dismissal.....

People leave jobs for different reasons. For example, you may leave of your own free will, or you may be asked or told to leave. There are different terms used for each situation.

- Resigned – gave notice that you wished to leave your place of work
- Retired – decided to finish your working life
- Dismissed – forced to leave by the employer
- Terminated – another term for ‘dismissed’
- Sacked – a colloquial or slang word for ‘dismissed’
- Redundant – being dismissed because there is no work for you to do
- Retrenched – being dismissed to save the employer money

Fair or unfair?

As an employee, you are entitled to notice of termination, usually four weeks. You may be made redundant by an employer or you may be retrenched. If an employer gives adequate notice and provides a dismissed worker with full entitlements, the employee is considered to be dismissed fairly, no matter how he or she may personally feel about it.

So what is unfair dismissal? Sometimes personality clashes arise between an employee and the boss, and the boss may dismiss that employee – a personality clash is not a valid reason for dismissal. Some workers may not be as efficient or as fast as others and be targeted for dismissal. Dismissal of women who get married or who are expecting a child and workers because they belong to a trade union are examples of unfair dismissal.

If a worker is dismissed for discriminatory reasons, that is considered unlawful and the worker has the right to appeal against the dismissal. Unfair dismissal laws have been written into the Workplace Relations Act which was revised in 2001 and again in 2008. Workers who believe that they have been dismissed on discriminatory grounds can lodge an application with the Australian Industrial Relations Commission. They must lodge an application with the Commission within 21 days of being dismissed. The Commission then considers things such as:

- whether there was a fair and valid reason for the dismissal
- whether the employee was notified of that reason and given the opportunity to respond
- whether the employee has been notified of any unsatisfactory performance.

Laws about unfair dismissal do not apply to workers who are employed by a company with less than 100 workers. This issue has been debated at length by politicians and employers in recent years. Also, the laws do not apply to workers employed on a seasonal basis, such as fruit pickers.



Rights and obligations

A worker who is dismissed has certain entitlements, which can include:

- payment for accrued annual leave
- accrued pro rata long service leave if the worker is eligible
- payment in lieu of notice – if an employee is told to leave immediately, he or she is generally entitled to four weeks pay in lieu, depending on the age of the employee and for how long she or he has been in continuous employment
- redundancy payments – in some cases, especially if the worker has been with a company for a long time.

If you believe that you have not received all your entitlements, you can contact the Australian Workplace Ombudsman (www.wo.gov.au).

Media Release – Workplace Ombudsman, Australian Government

13 January, 2008

Investigation into exploitation of Indian farm workers in the Riverina

Nicholas Wilson, the Commonwealth Workplace Ombudsman, has announced an immediate investigation into alleged exploitation of Indian farm workers at Rorato Nominees Pty Ltd (Rorato Nominees) tomato farm in the New South Wales Riverina town of Jerilderie.

The investigation follows reports in the Sunday Age and Sun Herald newspapers on 13 January 2008 alleging exploitation of Indian farm workers recruited by Primary Contracting Services Pty Ltd based in the NSW town of Leeton, also in the Riverina.

‘The alleged treatment of these vulnerable Indian farm workers is offensive and utterly contrary to the community’s expectation that all workers will be treated fairly and lawfully regardless of their nationality,’ Nicholas Wilson said. ‘Workplace inspectors from our Wagga Wagga office will commence an immediate investigation into the employment practices of Rorato Nominees to determine its fairness as well as ensuring that the workers have been paid all their lawful wages and entitlements. ‘The Workplace Ombudsman will liaise with other Commonwealth and state government agencies that may be examining this matter and refer to the appropriate agency matters which arise from our investigation that fall outside our jurisdiction.

‘The Workplace Ombudsman is concerned about unfair and unlawful employment of agricultural workers and recently issued a warning to employers of farm workers including season fruit and vegetable pickers around Australia to ensure these often vulnerable workers are treated fairly and that they comply with workplace law in their treatment of them,’ Nicholas Wilson said. The Workplace Ombudsman also recently conducted an unannounced audit of a berry farm in Victoria’s Yarra Valley following allegations of unfair and unlawful employment practices by the business.

*Media Inquiries: Suzana Talevski, Workplace Ombudsman Media Adviser
Ph: 0434 365 924
email: suzana.talevski@wo.gov.au*

Activities

- 1 Explain the difference between being retrenched and being made redundant.
- 2 Explain the difference between resigning and retiring from a job.
- 3 What is the essential difference between fair dismissal and unfair dismissal?
- 4 Sonia worked on the assembly line of a chocolate factory. She was caught by her supervisor eating chocolates while working and was immediately dismissed.
 - a Was she unfairly dismissed? Give reasons.
 - b Would the situation be different if the factory had a policy of allowing employees to eat chocolates off the assembly line? Explain.
- 5 Explain the meaning of each term.
 - a accrued annual leave
 - b pro rata long service leave
 - c payment in lieu of notice
- 6 Refer to the media release above about the exploitation of Indian farm workers in the Riverina.
 - a What was announced in the media release?
 - b By whom was the announcement made? Why?
 - c How was the situation dealt with?
 - d What basic human rights principle was being put forward by the Ombudsman?
 - e What is meant by ‘an unannounced audit?’ Where did one of these occur and why?



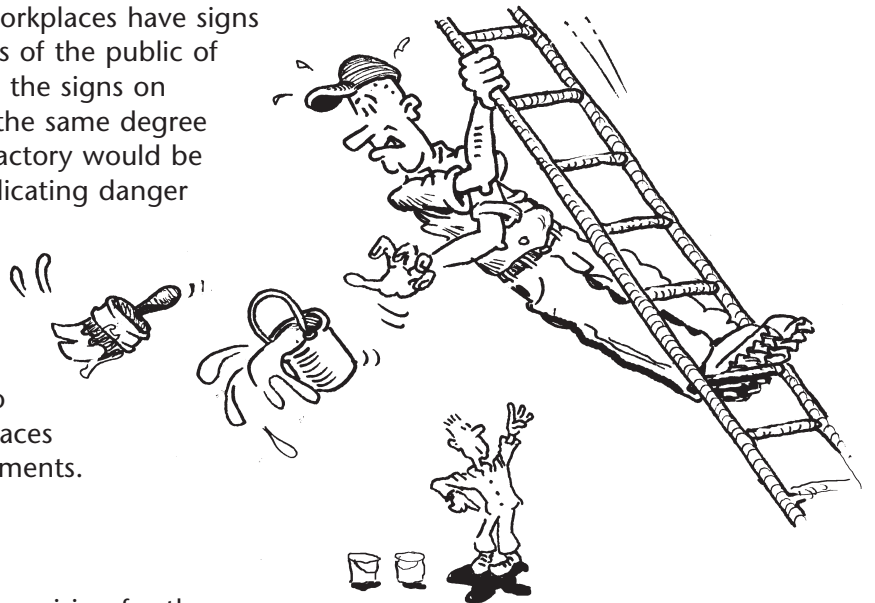
In pairs, discuss examples of fair and unfair dismissal. One person could come up with a scenario and the other has to judge whether it is fair or unfair. After discussion the roles can be reversed.

15 Occupational health & safety

Accidents can always occur in the workplace, just as they can in the home. Although some workplaces are potentially more dangerous than others, it is important that all workplaces are safe and safe practices are adopted. Each state in Australia has Occupational Health and Safety (OH & S) laws which set out the obligations of the employer in providing a safe working environment. Employees also have an obligation to work in a safe way so that they do not endanger themselves or others. In fact, each workplace is required to have an OH & S committee with representatives of employees and the employer to discuss current safety issues.

Positive action can save lives. Many workplaces have signs erected to warn workers and members of the public of possible dangers, as you can see from the signs on this page. Not all workplaces require the same degree of signage. For example, a chemical factory would be governed by strict rules with signs indicating danger areas and hazardous chemicals.

Even an office can have dangers such as faulty power points, exposed extension cords, furniture and office equipment that is not properly installed and may be likely to fall on someone. Therefore, all workplaces must be aware of the OH & S requirements.



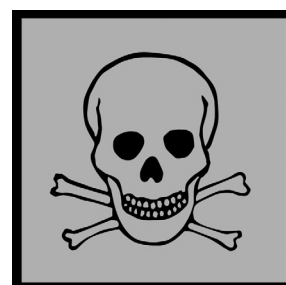
Workers compensation

If a worker is injured at work there is provision for them to be compensated and, if necessary, rehabilitated so that they can resume working when they have recovered. Compensation can pay for such things as medical and hospital costs, loss of earnings and permanent damage, disfigurement or loss of bodily functions such as sight and hearing. All employers are required to take out a special insurance policy to cover their employees for workers compensation.

Work Cover

Each state in Australia has a government authority to administer workers compensation claims. Two examples are Work Cover NSW and the Victorian WorkCover Authority. Their job is to assess claims and to make decisions on the amount and type of compensation required. Heavy penalties apply to people who make false claims. Where employers have been found to be grossly negligent in making the workplace safe, they may be prosecuted in a court of law and may have to pay damages.

There are work cover offices spread throughout each state, so that people have access to local services, where possible.



Lee decided to apply for a job in a local bakery. On his third day at work, he noticed that one of the dough-mixing machines had ceased to work even though all the others were operating. He told the owner of the bakery what had happened and the baker asked Lee to see if the dough was stuck in the machine. When Lee put his hand in the machine, it started working again and his hand suffered deep lacerations. Fortunately one of the other employees noticed this and turned off the power to the machine. There were no signs warning employees about the safety aspects of operating the machines. Lee's hand needed several stitches and he was unable to resume work for four weeks while the wound healed. He was entitled to workers compensation in the form of all medical bills being paid, as well as loss of earnings for four weeks.

The owner of the bakery was obliged by law to notify Work Cover who then investigated the incident. As a result of the investigation, the owner was given a severe warning and told to provide warning signs next to all machines.

Activities

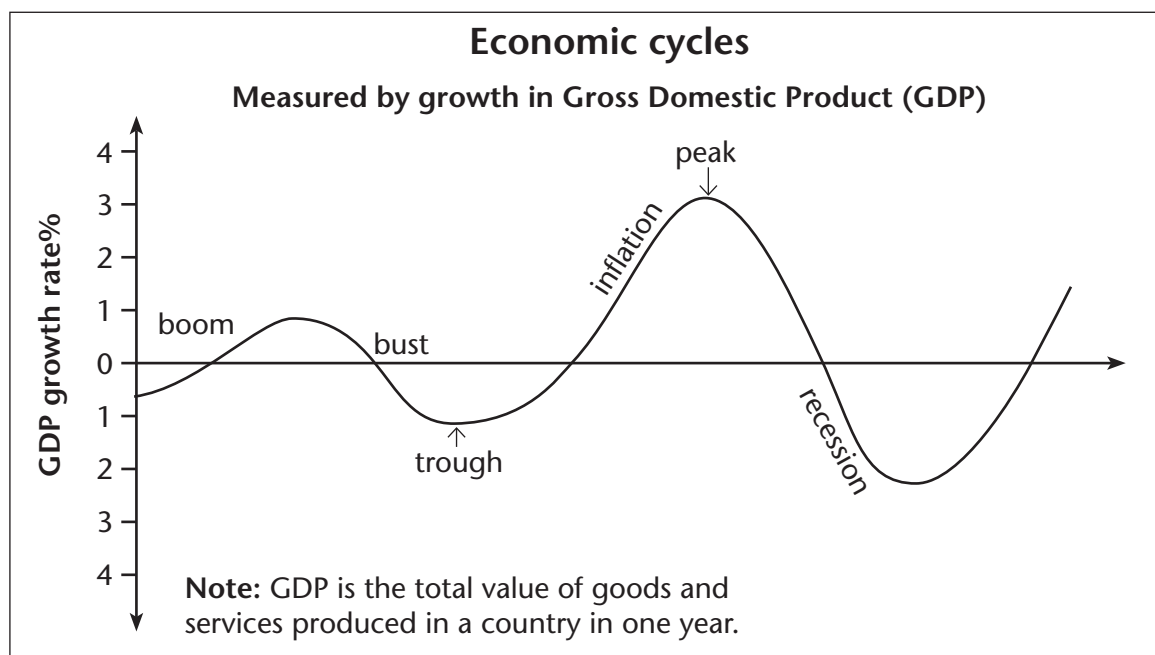
- 1 What does 'OH & S' stand for? Why is it important?
- 2 What are the obligations of the employer under OH & S laws?
- 3 Do employees have any obligations under OH & S laws?
- 4 Why must each workplace have an OH & S committee? Who are the members of this committee and what do they do?
- 5 Why are signs important in a workplace?
- 6 List five different types of workplaces. For each one, suggest what signs would need to be displayed.
- 7 Study the signs on the previous page. Write a sentence about each one, explaining what the sign is for and where it is likely to appear.
- 8 What is the purpose of workers compensation? Explain how it operates.
- 9 What is the role of the Work Cover authority in each state?
- 10 Are there penalties for false workers compensation claims? Why?
- 11 Andrew Jones is a weekend footballer. He injures his right leg playing football one Saturday. On Monday morning, he limps into work and pretends to slip over on the floor. He reports an accident at work to his local Work Cover authority. If you were a Work Cover employee, what would be your opinion of Andrew's behaviour? What do you think should happen to Andrew?
- 12 Read the story of Lee's injured hand.
 - a How did Lee's accident occur?
 - b Do you think it would have occurred if there was a warning sign near the mixing machines?
 - c How was Lee compensated?
 - d What did the bakery owner have to do by law when the injury occurred? Why?
 - e What happened to the bakery owner?
 - f What do you think would have happened to the bakery owner if Lee had been injured more severely and lost several fingers?
- 13 Using Lee's story as a model, write a story about a workplace accident that shows how workers compensation operates.



Study newspapers, magazines or the Internet to find stories of injuries at work. What were the circumstances? What happened as a result? How might the injuries have been prevented?

16 Current workplace issues.....

Even if you have a job, you should still follow current issues related to the workplace. The daily newspapers and television news and current affairs programmes are full of workplace-related stories. It is worthwhile to stay aware of the relationship between employment and the state of the Australian economy.

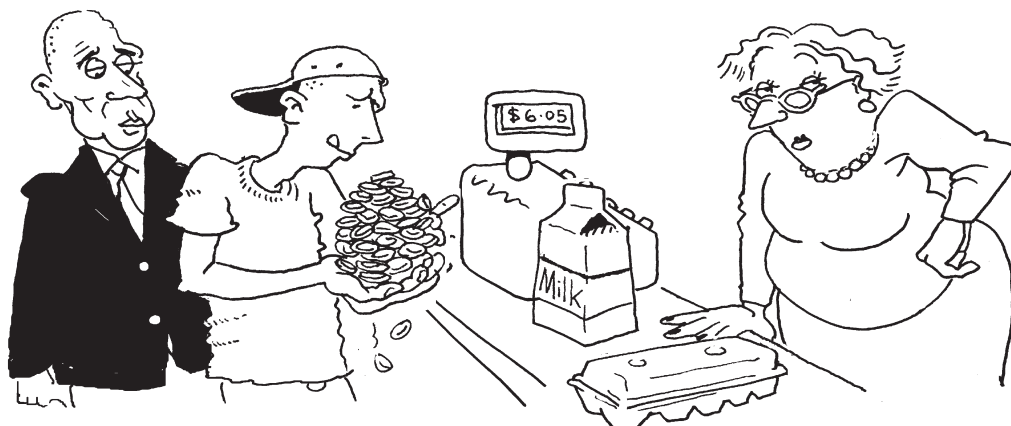


The economy and work

Whether you have studied Economics at school or not, you will probably understand that the level of economic activity in a country will fluctuate from time to time. The economy tends to operate in cycles, as you can see in the graph above. When the economy is booming, there tends to be an increase in retail sales, a rise in business confidence and a consequent fall in unemployment. This is good news for job seekers as there is a feeling that there are plenty of jobs to go around.

On the other hand, when economic activity is slowing down with a drop in retail sales, there is a consequent lowering of business confidence. Employers are more likely to lay off workers or not employ new workers. This can be very frustrating for new job seekers or people wanting to enter the workforce or change jobs. As you can see on the graph, terms such as 'boom' and 'bust' are used to describe mild swings in the cycle. Terms such as 'inflation' and 'recession' or even 'depression' are used to describe more severe swings. It is the task of the Federal government and the Reserve Bank of Australia to manage economic activity by trying to limit these excessive swings.

The state of the economy can be measured using economic indicators. These indicators can include retail sales figures, new housing approvals, wage and income levels and employment figures. They are readily available on the website of the Australian Bureau of Statistics (ABS).



Unemployment

The level of unemployment is the result of several factors. One is the level of economic activity and there are other factors, indicated by the main types of unemployment.

- **Structural unemployment** – Occurs as a result of structural changes in industry. Modern machinery and computer technology are putting some people out of work. There is a need for people displaced to retrain in different jobs.
- **Frictional unemployment** – Occurs when workers are in the process of changing jobs, or are having difficulty finding a new job after they've left the previous one. There will always be a degree of frictional unemployment.
- **Cyclical unemployment** – Occurs when the economy is slowing down. When economic activity is on the rise, unemployment is likely to fall.
- **Seasonal unemployment** – This is the result of seasonal changes, such as summer fruit picking, the shearing season, Christmas sales.

One of the aims of the Federal government is to maintain full employment. However, this is a difficult task given the types of unemployment described above. Sometimes target rates are set so that an unemployment rate of 5% or 4% may be considered acceptable.

Long term unemployment

This can be a serious issue for some people, especially those coming from migrant backgrounds with poor language skills. A person who wants a job and can't get one after a long period of time spent trying can suffer from loss of pride, loss of self confidence and self esteem. This can lead to social problems. People can get help from the Federal government through its Centrelink agency (www.centrelink.gov.au).

Activities

- 1 Why is it useful to follow the state of the economy even if you have a good job?
- 2 What are economic cycles and how are they measured?
- 3 What is the difference between a recession and a boom?
- 4 What are troughs and peaks in the economic cycle?
- 5 Why are retail sales figures and new housing approvals regarded as economic indicators?
- 6 How is the rate of unemployment an economic indicator?
- 7 What roles do the Federal government and the Reserve Bank play in managing the economy?
- 8 Indicate which type of unemployment is represented in the following situations.
 - a A severe drought in a wine-producing region
 - b More workers are changing jobs.
 - c Workers are being dismissed as computerised machinery replaces the work they do.
 - d There is a slowdown in economic activity in the country.
- 9 What is the role of Centrelink in helping the long-term unemployed? Visit the website and describe how this assistance is organised.



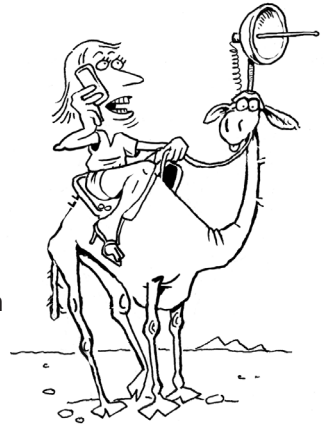
In groups, collect articles related to the economy, the workforce and unemployment. Prepare a collage of articles and discuss their content.

17 Technology and communication.....

The world is changing quickly in the development and use of technology. This is especially so in the workplace. The main advances have been in information and communications technology. Technology is changing the way people communicate, and the way that workplaces operate.

The Internet

The Internet is a worldwide network of computers linked by global telecommunications. It allows computers around the world to link and share information and resources. Growth in Internet use since the late 1990s has been spectacular. In Australia today there are six million subscribers. The Internet has enormous potential for use in the workplace. Business has become so reliant on the Internet that speed of access is now an important factor.



Office emails

The use of electronic mail or email has become a widespread means of communication for educational and personal purposes as well as workplaces. Email has advantages over regular postal mail in that it is delivered very quickly into the recipient's mailbox for them to read and reply to at their convenience. It is a very quick, easy and efficient way to communicate, despite the number of spam emails that clutter inboxes. Spam filters and antivirus packages can prevent this from getting out of hand and infecting computers, slowing things down and potentially causing damage to files.

Unlike a business letter, an email is informal and often uses informal language. It also has the capacity to attach documents which can be opened by the recipient.

Some differences between formal language and email language are listed below.

- Informal greetings – not using 'Dear Sir' or 'Dear Madam'
- Informal endings – not using 'Yours sincerely' or 'Yours faithfully'
- Capital letters and punctuation marks may not be used strictly
- The use of special abbreviation codes such as Cc and Bcc and informal terms such as 2L8, B4N, CUL8R, and FYI

Email etiquette

Overuse of emails can cause confusion and lead to delays at work as a recipient may struggle to keep up with the avalanche of information. There are no official rules governing email use, but there is a general consensus about what is called 'email etiquette' or acceptable behaviour.

- Keep messages concise – there is no need to tell the story of your life.
- Provide just enough information so that the recipient knows what you are talking about.
- Reply ASAP (as soon as possible), meaning by the next day where possible.
- Don't use upper case letters, as this can imply that you are angry.
- Try not to overdo email abbreviations as the recipient may not know what you mean. It is best to use more formal language in a work-related email. Try to use correct spelling and grammar as it leaves a better impression with the reader.
- Don't be over-familiar with your language, especially to someone who is more senior in rank, as they may not appreciate the informality.
- Make use of the attachment facility to email documents from your computer.

From: bamathers@unet.au
To: <alsmith@bigpond.net.au>
Cc: <bjones@ozemail.com>
Sent: Tuesday, 18 August 2009 3:43 pm
Subject: Sales figures for July
Attachment: Sales-July.xls (2.1 kB)

Hi Al

Attached are the july sales figures - hope you are pleased with them - let me know if you have any suggestions for future improvement. I have given Binah Jones an update too.

Barrie

- Use the Cc (courtesy copy) facility to inform others of your message. Where appropriate, use the Bcc (blind courtesy copy) facility to respect the privacy of the recipient.
- Don't write anything confidential or insulting in an email, as it shows lack of courtesy. Emails are regarded as written, official documents and can be used for official purposes. They can also be read by other people.
- Be wary of chain letters, 'get rich quick' schemes and other junk email messages. Do not even open them, simply delete.



Mobile phones

The growth in mobile phone use has been phenomenal throughout the world – from the early days of the clumsy first generation analogue phones, through the second generation digital technology with SMS messaging to the present day third generation (3G) miniature phones with all their extra features. In some less-developed countries, the mobile phone network is superior to the fixed line network, so much business is done via mobile phone.

Activities

- 1 Why has the Internet become such an important part of business? How is it used in the workplace?
- 2 How would you assess the importance of telecommunications in the workplace?
- 3 What advances have been made in Internet technology to make communication faster than ever before?
- 4 What is the term 'email' short for? What advantages does it have over the postal service and the telephone?
- 5 Explain the difference between Cc and Bcc in an email.
- 6 What are the main differences between an email and a business letter?
- 7 When should correct spelling and grammar be used in an email? Why?
- 8 Joe Blog has just sent you the email at the right. Rewrite it using more appropriate language. Then write an appropriate reply to him.
- 9 Study the list of email etiquette hints. Rank them in order of importance. Explain why the first two you ranked are the most important.
- 10 Why are mobile phones used so much in business? What advantages might they have over fixed lines (landlines)?
- 11 What are some of the 'extra features' now available on 3G mobile phones?
- 12 What equipment might be useful if you were given the job as a loans officer with a bank and asked to visit potential clients in their homes? Explain why.

From: Joe Blog
To: Y.Stavi
Subject: No cooperation

Hi Yussuf

Just thort Id make contact to let you no that youse peepke reely anoy me I have been doin my best to sell these widgets at a very fare price but youse are all ignoring me

Wake up to yourselves

Joe



Make a list of all the modern equipment that you would find in an average workplace, such as an office.

18 Learning at work

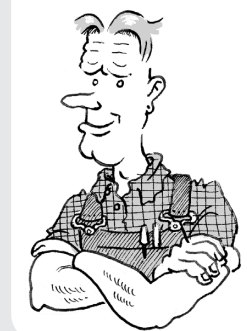
Once you have a job, it is a mistake to 'rest on your oars'. Learning is a life-long business, and you should never become complacent. Job security is not the same today as it was in the past, when employees could expect a safe job for life. Today there are no guarantees. On-the-job training is therefore an increasingly important aspect of workplaces today.

Learning at work may take many forms. It can be as simple and informal as group or branch meetings, one-on-one interviews with supervisors or discussions with mentors. Or it can involve additional courses at a TAFE college or a university to upgrade qualifications. You need to keep updating your skills and your qualifications, especially if you are in a job where there is strong competition.

Success in your career

Here are ten tips to help you enjoy success in your career through good workplace habits.

- 1 Create a life plan** – Success can be achieved if you know where you are going and have made a life plan. It doesn't have to be written down, although this helps to clarify goals and recognise achievements as they happen. A life plan involves outlining the direction you wish to take, what steps you have to achieve along the way and what barriers might delay or prevent success. A life plan can be flexible, depending on your personal circumstances, but even so it will provide you with a focus for your plans.
- 2 Act responsibly** – Be professional in all your dealings with people, whether they be work colleagues, supervisors or customers/clients.
- 3 Work efficiently and effectively** – Try to avoid time wasting. Focus on outcomes.
- 4 Make yourself irreplaceable** – Some people's work is so efficient and at such a high standard that they make themselves irreplaceable or indispensable. Aim to show your supervisor that no one can do your job better than you.
- 5 Be part of a network** – It is hard to work in isolation. You need to have people around you, contacts you can call on for help and people who show a positive attitude to their work. It doesn't have to be the 'old school tie' type of network – it can take any form and there is much you can learn from others.
- 6 Give credit where it is due** – Always acknowledge the good work of colleagues. Then they are more likely to acknowledge your good work.
- 7 Update your skills** – You may come to a job with a set of skills, but it is important that you not only maintain these skills but improve them. The world is constantly changing and so is the workplace. You need to stay on top of the possible effects of these changes. Keep on learning new things.
- 8 Upgrade your qualifications** – These are more formal in nature and involve courses at a TAFE college or a university. There is an ever-growing number and variety of courses available so look for the one that suits you best in your career.
- 9 Strike a balance between promoting yourself and boasting about your accomplishments** – This takes care, judgement and experience. It is good to talk to others, such as a mentor, about this.
- 10 Anticipate barriers** – There will always be times when things don't go your way, despite your best efforts. When this happens, act sensibly, not emotionally. Above all, do not lose your focus. Always remember that you can learn from your mistakes.



Jake was a team supervisor for a large company. He always wanted to take all the credit for the team's work. People in his team often became irritated by the way he talked about the solutions the team had come up with. Sometimes he would manufacture a problem and then come up with a solution which he claimed was his idea. When Jake was on holiday, the team worked in a more relaxed way, yet still got the job done.

Negotiation skills

One of the most important skills you can develop in the workplace is the skill of negotiation. Negotiation skills are critical, not only for doing your job well, but for advancing your career.

Some tips about success in negotiating are listed below.

- Develop a clear understanding of why you are negotiating. Consider what you hope to achieve.
- Speak calmly. Aggressive talk won't work.
- Be a good listener. Let the other person make their point and don't interrupt.
- Consider how the other person feels – in other words, be empathetic.
- Avoid comments like 'take it or leave it', or 'I just can't agree with that'.
- Choose your words carefully and also be aware of your body language.
- Be prepared to give a little ground – it makes the other person feel they have achieved something too.



Activities

- 1 What is the significance of the phrase 'rest on your oars'? What relevance does this have in the workplace?
- 2 Is job security likely to increase or decrease in the future? Give reasons for your answer.
- 3 How can you learn at work informally? Which methods do you think would be the most effective?
- 4 What methods could you use to upgrade your formal qualifications? Give an example.
- 5 What advantages are there in developing a life plan? How would you go about it?
- 6 Why is it important to act responsibly or professionally if you want to get ahead?
- 7 How can networking help in advancing your career?
- 8 Why is upgrading your skills important?
- 9 Why is striking a balance between promoting yourself and boasting important? How might you approach this problem if you were enjoying some success?
- 10 Why is the skill of negotiation so important? How can you learn or improve on this skill?
- 11 Describe the main elements of successful negotiation.
- 12 Read the story of Jake the supervisor.
 - a What was wrong with Jake's behaviour, given that his team achieved their goals?
 - b What options might members of Jake's team have for dealing with the situation?
 - c If you were a member of Jake's team, what would you say to him? Remember, he is your supervisor.
 - d What other options could the team pursue?



In groups, develop a typical life plan. Each group could take a different perspective – for example, a person interested in a science career, a person interested in succeeding in a large company or a person who is motivated by the arts.

19 Resignation strategies: knowing when to leave

Knowing when the time is right to leave a job can be just as important as choosing the right job in the first place. Many people find that the job they are in is not really suitable for them, and they don't need to stay and suffer. Workers really should be happy in their jobs, and many are.

There are some resignation strategies you should know about.

Thinking clearly about the decision

First, you should weigh up the pros and cons of resigning. What benefits would you lose? Would you be happier working elsewhere in a similar position? Or would you prefer an entirely different field?

Giving notice

When you decide that you want to resign, you are expected to give notice. This is usually done 30 days before your last day on the job. Giving notice allows the employer to make arrangements to replace you. Some organisations have a special resignation form while for others a letter of resignation is enough, as long as the exact date of leaving is included.

Some people don't give notice. This could be due to a bitter argument in the workplace, with the result that they can't stand to remain in the job a moment longer. By leaving before giving notice, a worker can lose some entitlements such as sick leave and holiday leave.

Also, some employers are not interested in being given notice. If an employee decides to leave, they may want that employee to leave their establishment immediately. There have been some cases of employees being escorted by security guards out the door. For the employer, there is the risk that a disgruntled employee may harbour a grudge against their employer and during the 30 days' notice may cause damage or access and steal company secrets. Policies on giving notice are therefore not always strictly enforced. Often the date of leaving is negotiated by mutual consent.

Burning bridges

Be careful in your behaviour when leaving a job, as you may find that in the future you are working for that same organisation again. In any case, it does not reflect well on any person to behave with bad grace. Also, a future employer may want a work reference from your previous employer and sometimes high value is placed on previous work references.

Tying up loose ends

If you want to leave in a positive way, it is important to tie up loose ends. Where possible, finish tasks that you have started and present the work you have done to your boss. You should also brief your boss on the progress of projects still unfinished. It will be much appreciated by your work colleagues and your employer.

Allie was not happy in her job. She found she was always fighting with work colleagues and always seemed to be in trouble with her boss over her work output. Allie decided to leave. She didn't confide in her supervisor or anyone else, for that matter. She simply didn't come into work any more.



Personal considerations

You may have talked to your work mates about the possibility of leaving. However, telling everyone that you will be leaving before letting your employer know shows a lack of courtesy. After your employer knows, then it is okay to tell other people.

Try to show your appreciation for the job, and for the help you have received in your work. While you may have mixed feelings about leaving, maybe some sadness, you should also be thinking positively. This is an opportunity for you to get on with your working life and accept new challenges.



James had been working for the XYZ Company for three years. He was happy and had achieved a lot, but he felt he needed to gain some more experience. He needed to move on. He decided to talk about this to his supervisor, who was very supportive and indicated that he too had changed jobs to gain more experience in different workplace situations.

Activities

- 1 Why is knowing when to leave a job just as important as choosing a job in the first place?
- 2 Should you be happy in your job? Why?
- 3 What are resignation strategies? What is the first thing you should do before going ahead and resigning? Why?
- 4 What is meant by 'giving notice'? Why is this necessary?
- 5 If you resign, what entitlements are you likely to have?
- 6 Why might some employees who have either resigned or been dismissed be escorted out of the premises by security staff?
- 7 If you are dismissed immediately, what rights or entitlements do you have?
- 8 What is meant by 'burning your bridges'? Why should you be careful to avoid this?
- 9 You have decided to resign and you want to leave on a positive note. How would you go about tying up loose ends? What does this mean?
- 10 Why is courtesy important when you are leaving a workplace?
- 11 Read James and Allie's stories. Outline the differences in their approaches to resigning and the different reasons they had for resigning. Should Allie have done things differently? Explain.



Working in pairs, conduct a series of interviews in which one of you is resigning and the other is your boss or immediate supervisor. Explain the reasons you have for resigning. Then swap roles for another interview where the employee and employer attitudes are different.

20 Life-long learning and pathways

The old traditional pathway was once: *leave school ➔ go to university or TAFE college ➔ get a job*. Today there are many pathways available to people which don't follow the traditional sequence. For example, a more common sequence today might be: *school ➔ job ➔ TAFE course ➔ different job ➔ university ➔ different job again*. Another pathway could involve overseas travel or what some people refer to as a gap year.

Gap year

Many people are not sure what they want to do in their working life after they leave school. Taking a gap year and travelling or working can be a good option. If you have gained a place at university or TAFE, you can defer your studies for at least a year, perhaps more. Taking a gap year gives you a breathing space and time to contemplate your future. You will also gain maturity, confidence and independence through a year off formal study. You can even work while overseas if you get a work visa or work at home before travelling overseas or in Australia. Most people who take gap years do not regret it.

University options

1. Mid-year enrolments

Universities today are far more flexible than in the past. You don't have to enrol or start at the beginning of the year, as there is the option of mid-year enrolment. You may have missed out on the course of your choice or failed to apply in time. You may even have wanted a short break before resuming your studies. The Universities Admission Centre (UAC) will have information available for you. However, there are usually less places available than at the beginning of the academic year.

2. Changing universities

If you find that the course you have started is not for you, or if your personal circumstances have changed, there are ways of completing your studies by changing universities. You can receive credits for courses completed at one university and finish a course at another, although there are obviously some rules which you would need to find out about.

3. Success doesn't require a uni degree

Many people think, quite wrongly, that a university degree is essential for success in the workplace. Many people achieve much with no formal qualifications. This doesn't mean that everyone should abandon the idea of a university degree, but it is not the only option. Today there are many TAFE college courses which today are designed specifically to suit particular careers – without the large course fees. Furthermore, university degrees are no guarantee of success in the world of work.

There is plenty of advice you can get from your Careers Advisor at school, from parents and friends, or from the many websites which specialise in this field. Start with Career Guide Australia at www.yourcareerguide.com.au.

Gillian

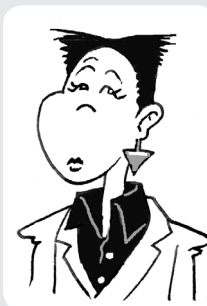


Gillian worked hard at high school and gained entry to university to study for Arts/Law. Gillian thought about deferring her degree and having a gap year. She had worked at a jewellery store on Thursday evenings and Saturday mornings for the past three years and had some savings and a burning desire to travel.

She decided to go ahead and defer her studies for a year and work full time in the jewellery store for a couple of months before going on a trip to the United Kingdom. Once she reached London, she gained some temp work in an office and travelled around on weekends. Then when she had accumulated more savings, she left her temp job and went to Europe where she backpacked for six months with a few English friends she had met. When she returned at the beginning of the following year, she realised that she had made the right choice. She had learned a lot about life in her time away and she felt she was now ready to settle down to her university degree.

Maya

Maya did not have a university degree but she was successful in the field of real estate. When she left school, Maya got a job with the local branch of a large real estate company and began selling houses. Her personality, charm and eagerness to learn on the job made her an instant success. She enrolled in a TAFE college course in real estate and gained the necessary qualification. After a few years she was promoted to manager of the local branch. Five years later, Maya decided to establish her own real estate office. Working with a small number of staff she continued to build on her success. Selling real estate is not easy. Although Maya could have enrolled in a university course, she created a successful business with minimum qualifications, but she did require enormous energy and skill.

**Keith**

Keith was a talented actor and writer who found that work opportunities were limited, so he decided to start a law degree at the University of Melbourne. He had completed three units of the course when his wife accepted a job as an arts director for a company in Darwin. He decided to approach the University of the Northern Territory to see if he could continue his law degree and gain credit for courses completed. This was granted and he did three more units of study. Three years later, his wife accepted an arts director job in Perth. He wanted to continue his legal studies and asked if he could complete his degree at the University of Western Australia. They accepted two of his three units from the Northern Territory, but this was acceptable to him. Keith went on to complete his law degree at the University of Western Australia.

**Activities**

- 1 What is meant by the 'traditional pathway' after leaving school?
- 2 How has this traditional pathway changed? Do you think this is a good thing? Why?
- 3 Suggest three possible pathways which are now available to young school leavers.
- 4 What is meant by a 'gap year'? What are its advantages?
- 5 Does taking a gap year prevent you from enrolling in a university course? Why?
- 6 Read Gillian's story. Why did she take a gap year? What benefits do you think she gained from it?
- 7 How can mid-year enrolments at a university be useful? Is this a sign of more flexibility in tertiary education? How?
- 8 Can you change universities midway through a course? Under what circumstances might this be necessary? Do universities place limitations on these changes? Give an example of when a university might refuse a change to another university.
- 9 Read Keith's story. Why did he change universities? What success did Keith have dealing with different universities?
- 10 Read Maya's story. Was Maya disadvantaged by not doing a university course? What qualifications did she have? Was this sufficient for success? What do you think was the secret to her success?
- 11 Brad left school after year 12 and decided to work as a shop assistant. If you were Brad's friend, what options would you suggest to him in seeking a future career?



In groups, discuss the different pathways available to school leavers. Discuss which qualifications are useful, and which are essential for the different career opportunities available. Record the conclusions reached on a display board.

21 Work wordfind

Find the words listed below in the wordfind. They may be horizontal or vertical.
The remaining 12 letters refer to the place where it all happens!

- | | | | |
|-----------------|--------------|-------------|----------------|
| • COMMUNICATION | • CASUAL | • RESUME | • SYSTEMS |
| • COMPUTER | • MANAGEMENT | • HEALTH | • RACE |
| • EMAIL | • OFFICE | • WORK | • LEADERSHIP |
| • BULLYING | • TAXES | • MANAGER | • BOSS |
| • HARASSMENT | • INFORM | • PATHWAYS | • ILL |
| • LETTER | • INTERVIEWS | • DATA | • UNEMPLOYMENT |
| • FACTORY | • SKILL | • ETIQUETTE | • PROMOTION |
| • APPRENTICE | | | |

E	M	A	I	L	O	F	F	I	C	E	P	T	P
W	O	R	K	B	H	E	A	L	T	H	R	W	A
C	O	M	M	U	N	I	C	A	T	I	O	N	T
O	A	A	A	L	C	H	T	E	O	N	M	R	H
M	P	N	N	L	A	B	O	S	S	F	O	H	W
P	P	A	A	Y	S	R	R	K	K	O	T	A	A
U	R	G	G	I	U	A	Y	L	I	R	I	R	Y
T	E	E	E	N	A	C	L	E	L	M	O	A	S
E	N	M	R	G	L	E	P	T	L	R	N	S	Y
R	T	E	T	I	Q	U	E	T	T	E	D	S	S
A	I	N	T	E	R	V	I	E	W	S	A	M	T
I	C	T	A	X	E	S	C	R	E	U	T	E	E
L	E	A	D	E	R	S	H	I	P	M	A	N	M
L	U	N	E	M	P	L	O	Y	M	E	N	T	S



Selected answers

I EMPLOYMENT IN AUSTRALIA

- 1 Australian Bureau of Statistics; provides statistics to the Federal government.
- 2 **a** 4.2%, increased. **b** 10 706 100 **c** The proportion of the working age population actually in the workforce, 65.4%, increased from 65.3%. **d** Seasonally adjusted figures were slightly higher in April 08. **e** It takes account of seasonal fluctuations, such as Christmas, Easter, harvest times, summer, winter. **f** Strongly upwards, indicating growth. **g** Downwards trend. **h** Summertime, or fruit-picking times when labour is required.
- 3 **a** 5.6% **b** Decreased, from 5.6% to 4.2%. **c** Increased, from 63.9% to 65.4%. **d** More jobs available, economy stronger, businesses expanding. **e** Sharper rises and falls in 2008 than in 2004. **f** 1 052 000 [10 706 100 – 9 653 700]
- 4 To provide detailed and ongoing information about the Australian workforce. Businesses, the government and many other organisations as well as individual citizens use them.

2 TRADE UNIONS TODAY

- 1 A group of workers united to improve their wages and working conditions.
- 2 Australian Council of Trade Unions. Formed in 1927. It speaks on behalf of the union movement.
- 3 Protection against unfair treatment, workplace health and safety, better wages and conditions, membership benefits such as loans and discounts, support for better workplace laws.
- 4 Trades and Labour Councils. They speak on behalf of state-based trade unions.
- 5 **a** 20% or 1 in 5. **b** Fell by 6.6%. **c** Casualisation of workforce, less support for trade unions generally. **d** Men, public sector employees. **e** Machinery operators and drivers, electricity and gas, water and waste services, education and training.
- 6 Policy relating to the rights of workers and the role of trade unions, set by the government of the day. Controversial because it can affect workers in one way and businesses in another.
- 7 People have strong political views about trade unions, from those strongly against to those very passionately in favour.
- 9 Kerry believes trade unions have brought benefits in wages and working conditions to ordinary workers through collective action.
- 10 Chris believes trade unions are disruptive by going on strike all the time and inconveniencing the public.

3 DEALING WITH DIFFICULT WORKMATES

- 1 It is part of human behaviour, which is often unpredictable.
- 2 Leadership style refers to the way a leader behaves towards his or her staff and can vary from autocratic styles to those which rely on consensus and mutual cooperation.
- 3 **b** Own view, but generally accepted that relationships such as this are acceptable as long as they do not interfere in any way with the work situation. **c** Autocratic boss who relied on intimidation. Probably did not respect his workers. Respect should be mutual and work both ways. **d** Own opinion, but may be sympathetic if it was the first time. If it happened regularly, perhaps say, 'We are here to work and I would prefer not to discuss personal matters.' **e** Perhaps jealousy or envy that Mandy had been promoted instead of them. Mandy could talk to them and reassure them of her continuing friendship, but explain that she had a different job to do now. **f** Ron could be reminded that the world changes very quickly and that new ideas should be given due consideration. Likewise, Ron is entitled to have his views respected.
- 5 Mutual respect means respecting others, and having others respect you too – regardless of who is the supervisor and who is being supervised.

4 CASUAL EMPLOYMENT PITFALLS

- 1 Casual employment involves irregular work. Part-time employment is regular work that is less than 35 hours per week.

- 2 Often on a weekly basis but sometimes fortnightly, based on the number of hours worked.
- 3 Casual workers do not have security of employment, nor do they receive benefits like paid sick leave, annual holidays or other special forms of leave.
- 4 False. Despite not having the same working conditions as permanent employees, they do have workplace protection under Occupational Health and Safety laws.
- 5 An understanding of the importance and value of work. It is important to employers as it demonstrates a positive attitude.
- 6 A contractor works for herself or himself and bids for a specific job for a specific payment, like a contract. A casual employee is employed on an hourly basis.
- 7 Employers who do not follow minimum standards in record keeping or taxation arrangements, shifts being cut without notice or explanation, shifts which are unfair, compulsion to buy expensive uniforms, first employees to be dismissed.
- 8 No. They are paid hourly and are not permanent employees.
- 9 Casual employees may be entitled to some proportion of long service leave or unpaid parental or carer's leave in some circumstances.
- 10 The right to be treated fairly and the right to safety in the workplace.

5 KEEPING THE CV UP TO DATE

- 1 Even if you currently have a job, you may want to apply for a promotion or change jobs at any time.
- 2 Computers have special software programs which sort CVs.
- 3 They can look for key words and phrases which identify an applicant's skills. This is so that the CVs with the right content can be identified quickly and then read more closely.
- 4 It would be confusing and would not reflect what the computer program is looking for.
- 5 It is a statement that indicates that a person is capable of doing a particular task or skill; for example, word processing.
- 6 It is easier to read and more likely to impress the reader.
- 7 Good communication skills between employees increase levels of productivity, as the employees work better as a team. Communication skills between employees and customers can result in income via sales or contracts, which is what businesses require to succeed.
- 8 Initiative, energy and enthusiasm are qualities which reflect a person's personality and therefore their ability to learn on the job and be more productive. Jobs which deal with members of the public are a good example, like sales.
- 9 The specialised words and phrases used in a job or an industry.
- 10 A job application must be specific and address the particular skills specified in the job ad, as these are the applications that the employer will consider in choosing a person for a role. If the employer can't easily see how the applicant fulfils the requirements, they may simply reject that application.
- 11 A generic CV is a 'one size fits all', listing general skills that may be irrelevant to a specific job vacancy. A specific CV is tailored to suit a particular job or type of job.
- 12 Aisha has specific skills related to typing, Internet and email skills, handling of basic office machinery like photocopiers and telephone systems. She would be suited for an office clerical job.

6 INTERVIEW SKILLS IN THE WORKPLACE

- 1 You may wish to apply for promotion or change jobs, or you may have an annual review which involves an interview.
- 2 Annual review interview, internal review interview, disciplinary interview, interview for promotion. Yes, as it depends on the circumstances, but a positive attitude is important in each interview type.
- 3 To assess progress over the past year and to find out if any improvements have been made or could be made in the future. Normally conducted by an immediate supervisor.
- 4 Advise him to admit his error, offer apologies and promise not to do that again – not an outright denial of guilt.

- 5** How you communicate with others without speaking, what signals your body sends, such as facial expressions, hand gestures and posture. Good body language involves smiling, facing people and making eye contact. Bad body language includes looking away or down, folding arms and scratching or picking at body parts.
- 6** Appearance gives a good first impression which is important in an interview. While people may wear casual clothes in some interview situations, they should be clean and neat, to give the impression that the interview is important to them and that they have taken care with their appearance.
- 7** No. It is always essential to be well prepared as you can anticipate questions and answer them more effectively. You can still anticipate the types of questions. You can also practise positive body language signals.
- 8** **a** For her annual performance review. **b** Emily was Sarah's supervisor and her task was to conduct a performance review. **c** Yes, as she was spoken to politely and praised, and was given some positive advice and help. **d** Advised to enrol in a TAFE course to further develop selling skills. **e** Extremely important, as it impresses others and suggests high productivity.
- 10** No. There are other methods such as examining an employee's output such as sales figures, amount of work done and quality of work.

7 WORK IN THE FUTURE

- 1** Greater use of modern communication technologies, widespread use of the Internet, emails, modern telephone systems, fully automated machinery in factories, e.g. car manufacturing assembly lines.
- 2** Machinery can now do the work previously done by unskilled workers.
- 3** De-skilling is when machinery is so sophisticated that it can do what a skilled worker can do and so that skill is in less demand, such as spray painting in car manufacture.
- 4** Allowing for different working hours, flexi-time, rostered days off, working from home, working from a mobile office. Providing bank loans or financial advice using a car and laptop and visiting a client's home.
- 5** Decreasing the workforce by eliminating middle management jobs. It is sometimes necessary to save money or to rationalise the tasks being done.
- 6** On-the-job training is very important as skills should be further refined and developed to make a worker more productive.
- 7** Less job security today than in the past, and more mobility in the workforce. It is easier to transfer to other jobs and to be retrained.
- 8** Profit-sharing offers, offers of shares in the company, pay incentives, annual bonuses.
- 9** Megan could apply for a job in a different IT company to gain more experience, or apply for promotion in her current situation.

8 WORKPLACE BEHAVIOUR: BULLYING

- 1** Yes. Many Australian workers are bullied in various ways in the workplace.
- 3** Personality clashes can mean people disagree with each other or can't relate to one another. Bullying suggests a one-sided conflict, usually with someone in a more senior role.
- 4** **a** False **b** True **c** False **d** True **e** False
- 5** **a** Yes, not a personality clash but an unreasonable demand and delivered in an abusive manner. **b** No, the time frame appeared unrealistic. **c** No, as he was polite and apologetic and requested help. **d** Perhaps Shelley's lack of time management and people management skills. If Shelley had given the job to Adam the day before, or listened when he asked for help, the list might have been completed on time. **e** Unrealistic demand with no help or sufficient time to complete the job and the abusive, aggressive attitude of the supervisor. **f** The boss would probably reassure Adam that the matter would be investigated. The boss would interview Shelley and advise her of her obligation to set reasonable tasks and to treat employees with respect.
- 6** **a** The bullying was a type of initiation behaviour with intimidation and inappropriate and dangerous practical jokes. **b** That this type of behaviour was common and acceptable practice. **d** Apprentice was paid compensation.

- 7** Report the matter immediately to a supervisor or other person in the organisation. If your complaint is not acted on, report the matter to the Anti-discrimination Board.

9 SKILLS REQUIRED FOR SPECIFIC JOBS

- 1** Yes. They may be basic, such as interpersonal skills and communication skills, but are still important and should be valued.
- 2** Self analysis is always useful. You should record them in your CV or in a computer document so they can be used later when applying for a job.
- 3** Skills involving meeting and relating to people, being a good listener, getting along with people and working cooperatively with them.
- 4** Skills required for a particular job. Typing skills would be a skill required for office jobs.
- 7** Student opinions, but as an example, a chef has to make decisions and delegate tasks.
- 8** **a** Labouring skills, graphic design or drawing skills including computer graphics, music and debating skills. **b** For example, graphic design or architecture. **d** Advise him to consider what he likes doing and what he is good at, and finding a match. He could get help from his careers advisor or relatives and friends, or people in the industries he is considering.

10 WORK ENVIRONMENTS: ETIQUETTE

- 1** Interested is your attitude to the job, interesting is how you impress others by your personality.
- 2** D
- 3** It is unprofessional and it may cause conflict with others.
- 4** Seek an interview with your supervisor and mention it politely. This is how the grievance is most likely to be resolved.
- 5** At first yes, unless the senior person invites you to use their first name.
- 6** **a** Being over familiar for a first contact. Sam should be more polite and careful in his use of language to create a better impression. **b** Jane is trying to be pleasant and polite and not abusive while still pointing out what is acceptable behaviour in the workplace. **c** As above, highlighting areas of behaviour which need improvement. **d** Personal behaviour not acceptable, being over-familiar, poorly dressed, not cleaning up after himself. **e** No. Even if his work is up to standard, his behaviour is not and should be fixed. **f** Point out that you are part of a team and you should pull your weight and not rely on others to clean up after you, also to show respect to other workers.
- 7** Christmas parties can be a trap for young employees, where behaviour standards may slip because of the party atmosphere. If the behaviour becomes too extreme there may be consequences later, such as drinking too much alcohol and forgetting to think before you say anything.
- 8** That it is not appropriate to use the office time and equipment for personal use unless there is an emergency.
- 9** When there is a family emergency such as the death or serious injury of a family member or close friend.

11 WORK ENVIRONMENTS: CULTURAL ISSUES

- 1** A workforce from many different countries, with different cultural backgrounds.
- 3** Because it is morally and legally wrong.
- 5** Women were historically treated differently from men, but this attitude has changed and most people now expect equal treatment for women and men in the workplace. Some people still act in a sexist manner.
- 7** Disabled workers are now being integrated into the workforce where possible. Sheltered workshops are not a form of integration and can discriminate unfairly against disabled workers.
- 8** Governments and private companies now have policies to actively encourage the employment of disabled workers.
- 9** Jonah felt he was too slow. Miriam's attitude was that he should be given a chance and treated with respect and understanding.
- 10** Laws which protect people from discrimination on grounds of sex, race, religion, etc.

12 WORKPLACE COMMUNICATION

- Words used should include interchange, ideas, facts, receiving and giving information.
- Good communication is essential in any workplace as people work together and need to exchange ideas, opinions and instructions in order to work effectively.
- Speaking, making a point, asking a question, listening to get feedback and understand instructions.
- 'The future prospects of the company are sound. There are plenty of opportunities for growth. The managing director and I believe we have the skills and expertise to succeed. Could you all submit your suggestions to Mr Jones and me for perusal.'
- It is a major form of written communication, regularly used and relied upon.
- They may be used in a court of law, they carry more weight in importance.
- a** Why are you late? **b** See you later **c** Thanks
d Tomorrow **e** Easy to see **f** Great **g** What do you think?
h Oh I see **i** You're on your own **j** Before
- Lyn could be advised to spend more time preparing and to consider the most effective ways of communicating.
- Making eye contact with the person talking, nodding to show you are listening, which is just as important as speaking.

13 TYPES OF MANAGEMENT STRUCTURES

- It helps with understanding what the workplace is trying to achieve and what your role is within it.
- Small: a corner store, a local branch office. Large: a government department, a large construction site.
- Sole trader: operates on own, accepts all the profits and bears all the losses, liability is unlimited. Partnership: like a sole trader except two or more people share the profits and risks. Companies: owned by shareholders and liability for company debts is limited to shareholdings.
- CEO or Chief Executive officer.
- The shareholders of a company.
- a** In a capital city such as Sydney or Melbourne. **b** In state capitals. **c** To allow people to access them more easily.
d At the head office. **e** So you know how it all operates, so you can show loyalty to the organisation and know where to go for help. **f** Finance Manager, Sales and Marketing Manager, Human Resources Manager. **g** Yes, in some cases, although middle management may be cut if a company downsizes. It also shares the workload if it can be justified.
h It shows who the next person in line to report to is if something goes wrong. **i** They illustrate a hierarchy and show who reports to whom.

14 UNFAIR AND FAIR DISMISSAL

- Retrenched is when you are dismissed to save the employer money, or if the business is going badly; redundant is when your particular job no longer exists.
- Resigning is when you wish to leave your place of employment; retiring is when you wish to cease your current working life.
- You may be dismissed fairly if the employer has not broken any laws or has acted correctly. Unfair dismissal can occur if an employer acts in a discriminatory manner.
- No, as it could be seen as stealing from the employer, unless company policy allows employees to eat chocolates while on the job.
- a** Accrued annual leave, leave which has built up over time.
b Long service leave at a rate that fits the time worked.
c Immediate payment to an employee who is leaving instead of forcing them to work out the notice.
- a** An investigation into the exploitation of Indian farm workers at a tomato farm in the Riverina of New South Wales. **b** Nicholas Wilson, the Workplace Ombudsman.
c Workplace inspectors were sent out to investigate the exploitation claims. **d** Basic right to their lawful wages and decent working conditions. **e** A check on the situation without prior notice given. It occurred at a berry farm in Victoria's Yarra Valley because of reports of unfair and unlawful employment practices.

15 OCCUPATIONAL HEALTH & SAFETY

- Occupational Health and Safety. It is important to protect workers from potential injury in the workplace.
- To provide a safe workplace and to obey OH & S laws.
- Yes, they should work in a safe way so they do not endanger themselves or others.
- OH & S committees are necessary to resolve local workplace issues as they arise. They consist of employee representatives and management and they discuss safety issues.
- They provide clear warnings about safety and dangerous places or practices.
- To compensate workers who are injured at work. Employers must take out a special insurance policy for this purpose and workers are able to receive payment for items such as medical expenses and loss of wages.
- Work Cover authorities administer the workers compensation claims.
- Yes, it is fraud to make a false claim.
- His behaviour is unacceptable as he was dishonest in reporting how he injured his leg. He could be warned or even prosecuted for making false statements.
- a** Lee put his hand in the mixing machine at the bakery in an attempt to free a blockage. **b** Probably not, although verbal warnings should also be given to reinforce the danger.
c Lee had all his medical bills paid and his lost wages for four weeks. **d** The bakery owner was obliged to notify the Work Cover authority of the injury and make a report.
e The bakery owner was given a severe warning and told to provide warning signs next to the machines. **f** The bakery owner could be taken to court and had damages awarded against the bakery for the loss of an employee's fingers.

16 CURRENT WORKPLACE ISSUES

- You never know when the economy might falter and you could be out of a job. Also, knowledge of the economy shows good citizenship.
- The economy is never static but fluctuates from boom or good times to bust or bad times, i.e. rising and falling economic activity.
- A recession is a time of falling economic activity and negative growth, while a boom is rising activity and growth.
- Troughs are the bottom of a recession period and peaks are the top of a boom period.
- They indicate how well the economy is going by how much spending is happening.
- If economic activity is slow and sales are falling, businesses will put off workers.
- The Federal government and the Reserve Bank are jointly responsible for managing economic activity and avoiding large swings in the cycles.
- a** Seasonal. **b** Frictional. **c** Structural. **d** Cyclical.
- Centrelink helps long-term unemployed look for work and also pays various allowances to those in need.

17 TECHNOLOGY AND COMMUNICATION

- The Internet is a very effective means of communication and its use is now widespread. It is used in the workplace for buying and selling, for communicating and for searching information.
- Telecommunications are very important as they are a fast and effective means of communication. New telephone technology, especially mobile technology, has revolutionised the workplace.
- Faster Internet access through broadband technology, the use of fibre-optic cable and wireless technology.
- Electronic mail. It provides immediate communication rather than waiting for letters to be delivered. It can be more convenient than the telephone as people can read their emails when they have time and not be interrupted by a phone call.
- Cc is courtesy copy (or carbon copy). Bcc is blind courtesy copy, where original recipient does not know a copy is being sent.
- Emails are quicker, they are more informal and spelling and grammar are not as important.
- Spelling and grammar should be used correctly in an important email such as a business offer or acceptance.

- 8** Hi Yussuf
Just thought I'd make contact to let you know that you people concern me. I have been doing my best to sell these widgets at a very fair price but you are all ignoring me. Please try to cooperate.
Joe
Student reply should be polite and not abusive.
- 10** Mobile phones are relatively cheap to buy, they are portable and in widespread use.
- 11** Cameras, Internet access, email access, TV access, music players.
- 12** A laptop computer and a mobile phone. The laptop will have all the loans programs loaded onto it and a mobile phone allows contact with head office or with the clients, as well as Internet access.

18 LEARNING AT WORK

- 1** 'Rest on your oars' implies coasting and not trying to improve your skills or do better at work.
- 2** Probably decrease. There is more mobility and job changing today than in the past and no jobs are lifetime guaranteed any more.
- 3** Informal meetings with supervisors, one-on-one interviews, branch meetings, attending conferences, enrolling in training courses. Most effective ones a matter of opinion.
- 4** Enrol in a TAFE course or a university course. Undertake a Law degree.
- 5** It gives you direction in your working life. You could sit down with pen and paper, assess where you are at and consider where you want to be and the steps needed to get there. Also, you could access an Internet site which assists in formulating life plans.
- 6** Acting professionally always gives a good impression to those above you and those with whom you work and who may later judge you for promotion.
- 7** Networking is about maintaining useful contacts in the workplace which help you find out about what is happening and what is available.
- 8** Upgrading skills is essential for almost all jobs. Even a highly skilled doctor is upgrading skills all the time.
- 9** You can promote yourself in subtle ways, rather than boasting which is too obvious and can alienate people.
- 10** Negotiation is about giving and taking, about coming to a mutual agreement and it is very important in business in order to achieve results.
- 11** Understand what you are negotiating about, speak calmly and clearly, be a good listener, consider the other person's point of view and try to understand it, choose words carefully, be prepared to give a little.
- 12** **a** Jake was trying to take all the credit for the team's success. This irritated the other team members. **b** They could approach Jake politely and tell him of their concerns. **c** Students should use polite language but indicate that the team has been successful and all team members should be praised. **d** You could take the matter to a higher authority in the organisation, as long as it was done sensitively and politely.

19 RESIGNATION STRATEGIES: KNOWING WHEN TO LEAVE

- 1** It is important if the job you are in does not suit you or you are not progressing as you would like.
- 2** Yes, you are entitled to be happy, it is important in life.
- 3** Procedures for leaving a job on your own terms. First, you should consider carefully whether this is the right decision because you don't want to burn your bridges.
- 4** Telling the employer formally that you are leaving and giving the date of your last day. It is necessary so the employer can replace you or reorganise the workplace.
- 5** Paid sick leave, holiday leave, long service leave, pay up to the last day of work.
- 6** They may feel you would not work as effectively or you may disrupt the workplace or damage sensitive equipment.
- 7** You are entitled to be paid up to your official date of leaving which may be up to 30 days in the future, also you are entitled to paid sick leave and holiday leave.

- 8** Leaving with bad grace or with bitterness does not reflect well on you – you may wish to return at some point in the future.
- 9** Speak to your supervisor about what you could do to help the organisation adjust or help train your replacement, if this is practical. Also finish off tasks which are incomplete.
- 10** Courtesy is always important, no matter what the circumstances of your leaving.
- 11** James felt he needed more experience but was positive and helpful to his employer. Allie was unhappy, troublesome and did not assist or cooperate in any way with her employer. Different reasons for resigning were based on a desire to gain more experience as opposed to unhappiness. Allie could have been more helpful and discussed things with her supervisor.

20 LIFE-LONG LEARNING AND PATHWAYS

- 1** School - university - job, or school - TAFE - job.
- 2** There are now more flexible pathways. It helps people still undecided about their future careers, or whose personal circumstances or preferences change.
- 3** e.g. School - job - TAFE course - job - university
- 4** School leavers deciding to travel overseas or interstate to gain life experience before starting a university or TAFE course. It allows people time to consider their options and gives them a break from studying.
- 5** No. Universities have more flexible rules now and they can grant a deferral to a student until a later year.
- 6** Gillian had a great desire to travel and wanted to pursue this course of action. She would have gained valuable life experience and maturity before returning to study.
- 7** It allows people to start a university course late, after perhaps working and finding that university study is necessary for them to get ahead. Universities are now more flexible, by taking mid-year enrolments and also taking more mature-age students.
- 8** Yes, depending on the specific rules of each university. It may be necessary if you, your family or your partner change your place of living. Yes, some limitations are placed on changes, especially if some courses are more highly ranked than others, such as law and medicine degrees and the subjects within those faculties.
- 9** Keith changed universities because his wife accepted a job in a different city. He was successful in most of his changes and was able to complete his degree.
- 10** No. Maya showed plenty of enthusiasm, personality and natural selling ability so she was successful. She studied at a TAFE college to gain the necessary qualifications. Her success was based on her natural abilities and personality.
- 11** Brad could be advised to consider that working as a shop assistant is a good start, and he could also consider other career pathways and undertake some tertiary study, or complete a store management training course.

21 WORK WORDFIND THE WORKPLACE

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